

Complementation and Common Ground: Discursive effects of Biblical Hebrew כִּי *kī*

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Abstract

Clausal connectives, such as complementizers or circumstantial markers, are highly grammaticalized functional elements. Nevertheless, part of their original meaning can persist after grammaticalization has occurred, so that a seemingly neutral clausal connective can be semantically or pragmatically marked. This article argues that such is the case for the highly polysemous Biblical Hebrew clausal connective כִּי *kī*. It shows that this clausal connective presupposes that the information content it introduces is in the Common Ground. Specifically, *kī* is used in three contexts: (a) to refer to discourse-old information, (b) to introduce information that the Addressee can accommodate, and (c) to present discourse-new information as part of the Common Ground, for discursive effect. The previously described wide variety of uses of *kī* (introducing object and subject clauses as well as causal, temporal, conditional, adversative, concessive, and resultative circumstantial clauses) can then be derived from contextual clues given the general function of marking Common Ground. Furthermore, I argue that this function of *kī* is related to its origin as a [+distal] deictic lexeme, which provides a parallel with similar complementizers in unrelated languages. The analysis thus adds to a growing body of evidence for the possibility of employing referential features in the left periphery to express relations between interlocutors on the one hand and information content on the other.

Keywords: complementizers; information status; Common Ground; [+distal]; Biblical Hebrew

1 Introduction

The Biblical Hebrew clausal connective כִּי *kī* can be used in a wide variety of environments.¹ Scholars have struggled to account for this variety, both synchronically and diachronically. This paper shows, based on an in depth corpus study, that *kī* has a primarily pragmatic rather than semantic contribution: *kī* is underspecified as to the logical relation between the two clauses it connects, but is chosen over alternatives when reference is being made to the Common Ground—roughly, the information shared between Speaker and Addressee. This enables a primarily synchronic account which treats *kī* as a relatively neutral clausal connective, only presupposing that the information it introduces is in the Common Ground. The various semantic relations it can mark can then be derived from this generic function given the right pragmatic cues.

In addition, I argue that the pragmatic function of marking Common Ground can be related to an erstwhile [+distal] deictic function of *kī*. Intuitively, information that is marked as [+distal] is seen as “near” the Addressee (because “far” from the Speaker) and therefore part of the Common Ground. Thus, the article also shows that clausal connectives can carry interpretative “traces” from earlier stages of the language, building on and supporting earlier work on European languages (Staps & Rooryck 2023).

In the remainder of the introduction I briefly describe the Biblical Hebrew data pretheoretically (section 1.1), and provide more theoretical background on the proposed relationship between [+distal]

¹I use “clausal connective” as a neutral umbrella term for any grammatical item that connects two clauses, whether that is in a hypotactic/subordinating or paratactic/coordinating relationship.

and Common Ground (section 1.2). In section 2 I describe my method and give an overview of the data. The following sections discuss the different uses of *kī* in turn, showing how each use derives from the core function of marking Common Ground (sections 3 to 7). Section 8 concludes. For readers unfamiliar with Biblical Hebrew, the appendix provides some background and glossing explanations.

1.1 Biblical Hebrew *kī*

The Biblical Hebrew clausal connective *kī* can connect clauses with different relations to each other, and maps in translation onto a range of English clausal connectives. Its use encompasses at least the introduction of object and subject clauses ('that', (1ab)), causal 'because, for' (1c), temporal/conditional 'when'/'if' (1d), adversative 'but' (1e), resultative 'so that' (1f), and concessive 'though' (1g).

- (1) a. Gen. 16:4: וַתֵּרָא בִּי הָרְתָה *wat-t-ēre' kī hārā-tā*
CONJ-F-see\PRET[3SG] COMP conceive\PFV-3F.SG
'And she saw *that* she had conceived.'
- b. 2 Sam. 18:3c: טוֹב בִּי־תִהְיֶה־לָנוּ מֵעִיר לְעֶזְרוֹ: *tōb kī t-ihaye lā=nū mē=ʿir la=zōr*
good COMP 2-be\IPFV[M.SG] for=us from=city for=help
'It is better *that* you provide support for us from the city.'
- c. Gen. 34:14: לֹא נוּכָל ... בִּי־חַרְפָּה הוּא לָנוּ: *lō' n-ūkal ... kī herpā hū lā=nū*
not 1PL-be_able\IPFV ... COMP disgrace it for=us
'We cannot (do this, give our sister to a man who is uncircumcised), *for* it is a disgrace to us.'
- d. Gen. 32:18: וַיֹּצֵא אֶת־הָרִאשׁוֹן לְאֶמְרָא בִּי יִפְגְּשֶׁךָ עֵשָׂו *wa-y-əṣaw ʿet hā=rīšōn lē=ʾmōr kī y-ipāgāš=kā*
CONJ-3M-command\PRET[SG] OBJ the=first to=say\INF COMP 3M-meet\IPFV[SG]=you.OBJ
'Esau
Esau
'He (Jacob) commanded the first [servant], saying, "*If/When* Esau meets you, ..."
- e. 1 Sam. 12:12b: לֹא בִי־מֶלֶךְ יִמְלֹךְ עָלֵינוּ *lō' kī melek y-implōk ʾālē=nū*
no COMP king 3M-rule\IPFV[SG] over=us
'no; *but* a king shall rule over us!'
- f. Gen. 31:36: מַה חָטָאתִי בִּי דָלַקְתָּ אַחֲרַי: *mah haṭṭā-tī kī dālaq-tā ʾahār=āy*
what sin\PFV-1SG COMP chase\PFV-2M.SG behind=me
'How have I (Jacob) sinned *that* you (Laban) have chased after me?'
- g. 2 Sam. 12:12: כִּי אַתָּה עָשִׂיתָ בְּסֵתֶר וְאֲנִי אֶעֱשֶׂה אֶת־הַדָּבָר הַזֶּה נֶגֶד כָּל־יִשְׂרָאֵל *kī ʾattā ʾāśī-tā b=as=sāter wa=ʾānī ʿ-εʿšē ʿet had=dābār haz=ze*
COMP you do\PFV-2M.SG in=the=secret and=I 1SG-do\IPFV OBJ the=thing the=this
neḡed kāl yisrāʾel
before all.of Israel
'*Though* you have acted in secret, I will do this before all of Israel.'

In a broader typology of clause linkage based on parameters described by Lehmann (1988), *kī*-clauses behave most like "weakly desententialized noun clause[s] introduced by a universal subordinator", a type which also covers English *that*-clauses (e.g., *He believed [(that) I wrote a letter]*; Lehmann

1988: 218). This assessment is based on various properties. First, *kī*-clauses can link clauses to clauses (in circumstantial uses) or to VPs/NPs (in complementizer uses), but there is no evidence for incorporation of *kī* into the matrix predicate and *kī*-clauses therefore retain a high degree of independence (e.g., in (14) below a prepositional phrase appears before *kī*). Second, unlike highly nominalized clauses (e.g. *her conceiving* instead of *she had conceived*; cf. (1a)), *kī*-clauses express tense and aspect and have relatively free word order (note the fronting of a prepositional phrase in (8) below).² The low degree of internal nominalization goes hand in hand with a lack of distributional properties characteristic of NPs, such as adjectival modification, coordination with NPs, and selection by a large set of prepositions (in reality, only *ʾal* ‘on’ and *ʾad* ‘until’ select *kī*-clauses). Finally, *kī*-clauses cannot be “interlaced” with matrix clauses by sharing arguments or predicates (as is the case in, for instance, gapping and raising constructions).

Most scholarly discussion has focused not on structural and distributional properties of *kī* but on its functions.³ In particular, the large variety of contexts in which *kī* appears raises the question whether these different environments correspond to different functions of *kī* or whether these environments share certain properties that explain why *kī* is used in all of them. Scholarship in the past century or so has oscillated between describing *kī* as highly polysemous and highly abstract.⁴ Thus, whereas some have argued that all (or at least most) uses of *kī* can be reduced to a single semantic core (e.g. Muilenburg 1961; Schoors 1981), recent scholars have claimed that diachronic processes like grammaticalization have led to a highly polysemous lexeme (e.g. Locatell 2017, 2020).⁵

Regardless of these differences, the point of departure for both synchronic and diachronic approaches has been deixis. It is generally accepted that *kī* derives from an originally deictic morpheme **ka*, which has similar reflexes in at least Phoenician, Aramaic, and Arabic (Lipiński 2001: §49.9). Scholars in the synchronic tradition have generally tried to describe all uses as somehow deictic (e.g. Muilenburg 1961; Schoors 1981), whereas those with a primarily diachronic approach suggest possible grammaticalization paths from deictic origins (e.g. Locatell 2017).

What has not been given attention, unfortunately, is that **ka* is specifically a *distal* deictic morpheme, referring to things at some distance from the Speaker. This is especially clear in West Semitic,

²Because volitive forms are frequently indistinguishable from regular prefix conjugation forms, it is hard to establish with certainty whether *kī*-clauses are restricted with respect to mood. Job 27:8 appears to be the only unambiguously volitive form in a *kī*-clause in the Hebrew Bible, but its reading is contested (Dhorme 1967: 382–383). *Kī*-clauses are definitely restricted in terms of illocutionary force: though there are examples of imperatives and interrogatives in *kī*-clauses, they are used rhetorically and do not have full illocutionary force: ‘Only fear Yahweh ..., *for* look at what great things he has done with you!’ (1 Sam. 12:24); ‘What will be done for the man who slays this Philistine ...? *For* who is this uncircumcised Philistine that he should taunt the armies of the living God?’ (1 Sam. 17:26).

³A recent exception is Park (2016, 2023), who suggests that *kī* should be described as a “nominalizer”. Though the analysis in this article is compatible with this idea, my own assessment based on Lehmann’s (1988) parameters is different. Park (2015, 2016) suggests that both *kī* and *šer*, traditionally analyzed as a relativizer/complementizer, are nominalizers. This is based on a functional comparison to nominalizers such as Chinese *zhe*, which likewise form subject, object, relative, circumstantial, and matrix clauses. However, Park disregards distributional characteristics like the ones proposed by Lehmann (1988). For instance, unlike *kī* and *šer*, *zhe* can be modified by quantifiers and demonstratives (see also Holmstedt 2016: 89 n. 70). The problem is worse for *kī*-clauses than for *šer*-clauses, since they are even less noun-like than the latter, as can be seen from the smaller number of prepositions that can select them (Staps 2024a). Furthermore, the grammaticalization path of *zhe* depends on the availability of pre-nominal modification (Yap & Wang 2011: 65), whereas modification is post-nominal in Biblical Hebrew. Consequently, Park’s comparison does not go beyond functional similarities. While the functional overlap with Chinese *zhe* and other nominalizers remains interesting, it is unclear whether it can or needs to be explained with a unified synchronic analysis or shared grammaticalization path. Nevertheless, I stress that my analysis of *kī* is compatible with that of Park (2016, 2023).

⁴See in particular Redslob (1835), Vriezen (1958), Muilenburg (1961), Schoors (1981), Bandstra (1982), Claassen (1983), Thorion (1984), Aejmelaeus (1986), Gross (1991), Benigni (1999), Follingstad (2001), Park (2016), and Locatell (2017, 2020, 2025). Some passages in works with a broader scope are relevant as well: Watts (1964: 118–149); Muraoka (1985: 158–164); Van der Merwe (1993: 38–41); and Conklin (2011: 46–59). I will not summarize related work here, as this has been done recently by Locatell (2017); instead, I only refer to these earlier sources where relevant to the argumentation of the present article.

⁵Follingstad is an exception: he attempts to reduce *kī* to a “discourse deictic particle” with the function of setting up a new Mental Space and shifting viewpoint to this space. However, it is not clear that the Mental Space Theory is precise enough to exclude uses of *kī* that do not occur, and in some cases it actually makes incorrect predictions. For example, Follingstad (2001: 268–269) claims that *kī* can introduce a “hypothetical” conditional to which the Speaker does not need to commit, while the Speaker does need to commit to the truth of conditionals introduced by *im* ‘if’. This is contrary to the consensus in the literature. In section 6.2 I show that the consensus can be maintained.

where **ka* also appears in demonstrative paradigms. According to Hasselbach, **ka* “regularly marks far [i.e., distal] deixis in those languages in which it occurs” (Hasselbach 2007: 3).⁶ As will become clear below, this [+distal] feature forms the basis for an analysis according to which *kī* makes the pragmatic contribution of marking Common Ground.

In short, the *empirical result* I present is that *kī* is used to introduce information that is in the Common Ground. The description is primarily synchronic: roughly, *kī* is used when the information content of the complement clause is in the Common Ground, and the particular interpretation as causal, temporal, conditional, etc., largely depends on context.⁷ However, unlike previous authors with a synchronic approach, I also contrast *kī* with alternatives, to show that information that is not in the Common Ground is introduced in a different way.⁸ Under this analysis, only minor diachronic assumptions will be necessary. This is important, because any diachronic developments leading to the high number of uses in which *kī* can be used must have occurred before the appearance of written sources. Such diachronic developments can therefore be made conceivable on the basis of cross-linguistic parallels, but they cannot be tested on the Hebrew data themselves. The *theoretical analysis* I propose is that *kī* marks Common Ground because of an original [+distal] specification.

1.2 Theoretical framework

The notion that [+distal] markers can develop into markers of Common Ground status is based on previous work on (Indo-)European languages by Staps & Rooryck (2023). The idea can be illustrated with English *that*. The basic use of demonstrative *that* is to mark spatial distance (**this/that book over there*). However, in addition to this exophoric use, demonstratives have endophoric uses where they do not refer to a concrete entity in the physical world (Diessel 1999: 93–109). In these uses, other factors than spatial distance become relatively more important in the choice between *this* and *that*. These include psychological factors, such as whether the referent is in joint attention or not (Peeters, Krahmer & Maes 2021). For instance, Colasanti & Wiltschko (2019, 2025) show that in several unrelated languages, proximal demonstratives are used to introduce entities that are novel to the Addressee (e.g., *this book I read*), whereas distal demonstratives are used to refer to familiar entities (e.g., *that book we talked about*).

Staps & Rooryck (2023) relate this to a line of research on complementizer *that* starting with Storms (1966) and Bolinger (1972), who show that *that* is preferred to a zero complementizer when referring back to already given information (i.e., which is in the Common Ground) or establishing objective facts (i.e., setting up Common Ground). For this reason, Staps & Rooryck (2023) propose that the [+distal] feature of the English demonstrative *that* is still present, but differently interpreted, when *that* is used as a complementizer. In particular, distal *that* can mark both “actual distance” and “Addressee involvement”: the first is most prevalent in exophoric demonstratives; the second in endophoric demonstratives and derived complementizers. The specific interpretation of Addressee involvement follows from

⁶Lipiński (2001: §36.35, 36.37, 36.41) lists some demonstratives in Semitic and more remotely related Afro-Asiatic languages where **ka* appears to be used in proximal contexts, but these amount only to a handful of isolated instances, whereas the distal examples in West Semitic are more frequent and paradigmatic. In some languages where forms going back to **ka* are in paradigmatic contrast with the third person personal pronoun used as a [+distal] demonstrative, it appears that the forms based on **ka* are not distal but medial, referring to something near or known to the Addressee (e.g., ‘give me *that* (from **ka*)’ referring to an object near the Addressee; Jewish Babylonian Aramaic; Bar-Asher Siegal 2013: 82). This is compatible with my analysis, but a discussion of these demonstrative forms is out of scope here.

⁷One occasionally finds generic arguments against such a reductionist approach (Aejmelaeus 1986: 195; Locatell 2017: 114). However, the persistence of lexical meaning is, in fact, entirely expected in grammaticalization processes (Hopper 1991: 28–30). It is therefore not surprising if aspects of the [+distal] deictic meaning of Semitic **ka* are preserved in Biblical Hebrew *kī*, and my claim is that this is the most economical description of the data.

⁸This account aligns perhaps most with that of Park (2016), who likewise argues that different uses of *kī* are not different functions but arise from different contexts. However, the way in which this genericity arises is different. Park argues that *kī* is a nominalizer in the sense of Yap, Grunow-Härsta & Wrona (2011), and points out that, cross-linguistically, nominalizations tend to occur in a wide variety of contexts. By contrast, according to the analysis presented here, the genericity arises because *kī* is a neutral clausal connective that only specifies that the information it introduces is in the Common Ground. Thus, the claim is more precise: the set of environments in which *kī* appears is exactly the set in which information in the Common Ground is introduced. This is compatible with, but not dependent on, Park’s nominalization analysis (see footnote 3); hence my use of the noncommittal umbrella term “clausal connective”.

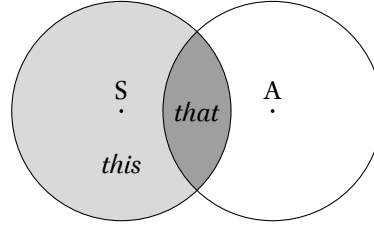


Figure 1: The information content tracked by the Speaker and Addressee. The intersection, the Common Ground, is seen as “far” from the Speaker (Staps & Rooryck 2023: 7).

the syntactic context: reference to familiar (as opposed to novel) entities in demonstrative *that*; reference to Common Ground and familiar information in complementizer *that*.⁹ The model is summarized in fig. 1 (reproduced from Staps & Rooryck 2023: 7). Information content is positioned in an abstract space around Speaker (S) and Addressee (A). The Common Ground (shaded dark gray) is accessible to both interlocutors. It is conceptualized as “close” to the Addressee and relatively “far” from the speaker when compared to information content that is not shared with the Addressee (shaded light gray). Even though the two gray regions are equally accessible to the Speaker, languages use [–distal] and [+distal] forms to refer to the light gray and the dark gray region, respectively. Thus, while the distance is measured from the Speaker’s origo, it reflects the accessibility to the Addressee, i.e., Common Ground status.

Speakers can exploit distance in this abstract space in three ways. In the most basic cases, [+distal] forms are used to *refer to discourse-old information content* (which is in the Common Ground), as opposed to discourse-new information content. For instance, it has been noted that emotion verbs, which are factive (presuppose their complement) are more felicitous when their complement is introduced by complementizer *that*, marking the information content as discourse-old:

- (2) a. ?*I’m glad losses were light.*
b. *I’m glad **that** losses were light.* (Bolinger 1972: 57)

A near-minimal pair can be found in Biblical Hebrew in Genesis 12, where Abram suggests to his wife Sarai that she does not tell Pharaoh of their being married. The idea is new to Sarai and therefore introduced in a zero-marked complement clause in (3). Eventually, Pharaoh finds out and requests an explanation from Abram. Since Pharaoh knows that Abram knows that Sarai is his wife, this information is introduced in a *kī*-clause in (4).

- (3) Gen. 12:13: אִמְרִי-נָא אֶחָתִי אֵת
'imr-ī nā' 'āḥōt=ī ātt
say\IMP-F.SG please sister=mine you
‘(Abram said to his wife Sarai: “...) Please say Ø you are my sister.”’
- (4) Gen. 12:18: וַיִּקְרָא פַרְעֹה לְאַבְרָם וַיֹּאמֶר ... לָמָּה לָאֵתְגַּדַּתְ לִי כִּי אֵשְׁתָּתָּהּ הִוא׃
way-y-iqrā' p̄ar'ōh lə='abrām way-y-ō'mer ... lāmmā lō'
CONJ-3M-call\PRET[SG] Pharaoh to=Abram CONJ-3M-say\PRET[SG] ... why not
higgad-tā l=ī kī išt=akā hī
inform\PFV-2M.SG to=me COMP wife=yours she
‘So Pharaoh called Abram and said: “... Why did you not tell me *that* she is your wife?”’

⁹Staps & Rooryck (2023) introduce the term “Shared Discourse Space” for the region tracked by both the Speaker and the Addressee. Shared Discourse Space is more general than Common Ground and does not only contain information content. Since this article deals exclusively with the sentential domain, the more common term “Common Ground” suffices here. The argument is fully compatible with an analysis based on Shared Discourse Space, should this be needed for data not covered in this study.

Additionally, there are two contexts in which discourse-new information content can be presented as part of the Common Ground. Declarative sentences with discourse-new information content are typically modeled as a request or proposal to update the Common Ground (cf. Farkas & Bruce 2010: 92). However, by explicitly placing the content “near” the Addressee with a [+distal] element, the Speaker can present it as already being in the Common Ground, thus signaling that they expect that the request for a Common Ground update will be granted—that is, that the Addressee can *accommodate* the new information content. For instance, in (5b), English *that* introduces an exclamative sentence. The information content of exclamative sentences is not at-issue and so the Speaker of (5b) expects the Addressee to be able to accommodate it (if it is not yet discourse-old; cf. Zanuttini & Portner 2003). By contrast, the same sentence without *that* in (5a) is a regular declarative sentence; the information content is at-issue and the Speaker makes a request to update the Common Ground that can be denied (note that *No, it isn't* is a felicitous response to (5a) but not (5b)).

- (5) a. *Bio industry is still allowed.*
 b. *That bio industry is still allowed!* (Staps & Rooryck 2023: 1204)

A Biblical Hebrew example of accommodation is in (6). Here, the Addressee (i.e., the reader) does not yet know that the man could not overpower Jacob, but this new information can easily be accommodated on the basis of the fact that they have already been wrestling for quite some time.¹⁰

- (6) Gen. 32:25–26: וַיִּאָבֶק אִישׁ עַד עֶלְוֹת הַשָּׁחַר: וַיֵּרָא כִּי לֹא יָכֹל לֵא: וַיֵּרָא כִּי לֹא יָכֹל לֵא
 way-y-ē'ābēq ṭš 'imm=ō 'ad 'ālōt haš=šāḥar
 CONJ-3M-wrestle\PRET[SG] man with=him until go_up\INF.of the=daybreak
 way-y-ar' kī lō' yākōl l=ō
 CONJ-3M-see\PRET[SG] COMP not be_able\PFV[3M.SG] to=him
 'And a man wrestled with him (Jacob) until daybreak, and he (the man) realized *that* he could not overpower him (Jacob).'

Alternatively, the Speaker may present discourse-new information as already being in the Common Ground in order to emphasize that they do not allow the Addressee to reject the proposal to update the Common Ground: the Speaker *imposes* the content on the Common Ground. In the English example in (7), the content of the embedded clause is new to the Addressee; it is imposed in the sense that it *must* be accommodated (Bianchi & Frascarelli 2017; see also Kocher 2022: 176–177):

- (7) *We regret that we cannot accommodate pets.* (Bianchi & Frascarelli 2017: 15)

Thus, imposition is a narrow, well-defined category in which the Speaker asserts their authority over the conversation by forcing new information into the Common Ground. The Biblical Hebrew example in (8) belongs to the same category. Here, David, an Israelite, has sought refuge with the Philistine king Achish. When the Philistines prepare to fight Israel, Achish makes sure that David knows he expects him to fight on the side of the Philistines. This is not something they discussed before and it cannot be easily accommodated. *Kī* here serves the function of signaling that the proposal to update the Common Ground cannot be rejected: David cannot refuse.¹¹

- (8) 1 Sam. 28:1: וַיֹּדַע כִּי אֶתִּי תֵצֵא בְּמַחֲנֶה
 t-ēda' kī 'itt=ī t-ēšē' b=am=maḥṇe
 2-know\IPFV[M.SG] COMP with=me 2-go_out\IPFV[M.SG] in=the=camp
 '(And Achish said to David:) "You should know ... *that* you will go out with me in battle."

¹⁰More examples of accommodation are in (17), (20), and (23–24) below.

¹¹More examples of imposition are in (19), (25), and (51) below.

To summarize, presenting information content as “near” the Addressee can simply mark it as discourse-old or easily accommodated, but can also have the function of signaling to the Addressee that they cannot refuse the update to the Common Ground. With the theoretical framework set up, the following sections aim to show that Biblical Hebrew *kī* marks reference to the Common Ground by presenting information content as “near” the Addressee.

2 Method and overview of the data

This study is based on an exhaustive analysis of the 808 uses of *kī* with a clausal complement in the narrative portions of the biblical books Genesis, Judges, Samuel, and Ruth. These books are considered to be similar in terms of time and place of origin, and thus form a relatively homogeneous corpus.¹² I focus on narrative texts because these contain most direct speech, where we can expect the interaction with Common Ground to be the largest.¹³ However, I also included uses of *kī* outside direct speech. Therefore, in direct speech the terms “Speaker” and “Addressee” refer to story participants, but outside direct speech they refer to the narrator and reader, respectively.

Each instance of *kī* was classified as belonging to a certain use type (e.g. causal, complementizer, etc.). My classification of each instance can be found in the data set accompanying this article (Staps 2023). The use types are based on the common categories found in reference works and literature on *kī*: (a) introducing object and subject clauses (‘that’; tagged as “complementizer”), (b) causal ‘because, for’, (c) adversative ‘but’, (d) causal-adversative ‘not X, *because/but rather* Y’, (e) conditional ‘if’, (f) temporal ‘when’, (g) resultative ‘so that’, and (h) concessive ‘though’.¹⁴ Instances where the *kī*-clause does not seem to relate to a corresponding “main” clause were classified as (i) standalone; this group will be further subcategorized in section 7. Five cases were ambiguous; I ignore them here for ease of exposition.¹⁵ I also excluded instances of the fossilized construction *כִּי יִמ* *kī ’im* and two instances of bare *kī* in the meaning ‘except’, which I assume to have grammaticalized more or less independently (pace Park 2023; see Staps 2024a).

Each instance was also tagged for the way it interacts with the Common Ground. As explained in section 1.2, the information content of the *kī*-clause can be (a) discourse-old and thus part of the Common Ground, (b) easily accommodated by the Addressee as new Common Ground, or (c) imposed on the Common Ground by the Speaker for discursive effect. There are some cases where the information content in the *kī*-clause does not fit either of these cases; these were classified as (d) rest. I will discuss these separately below, to show why they do not constitute counter-examples for my claim that *kī* marks reference to Common Ground. Nevertheless I also include many examples where information is in the Common Ground, in order to demonstrate the ways in which this can be used in discourse. Figure 2 shows the distribution of types of reference to the Common Ground for each use type of *kī*; the numbers from which this graph has been compiled are provided in table 1.

It can immediately be seen that in the vast majority of cases, the information content of the *kī*-

¹²Biblical Hebrew texts are usually divided into Early and Late Biblical Hebrew according to whether they are written before or after the Judean exile in 586 BCE (Young & Rezetko 2008: 7). Genesis, Judges, and Samuel are generally dated as pre-exilic (Young & Rezetko 2008: 10–11). Certain passages that are frequently dated to an even earlier stage (Archaic Biblical Hebrew: Genesis 49; Judges 5; 2 Samuel 22) are excluded here because they are poetic. Ruth is generally considered to have been written in the post-exilic period using an archaizing style (Young & Rezetko 2008: 99, 138). This makes it somewhat of an edge case, but the 28 instances of *kī* in Ruth follow the same patterns as those in Genesis, Judges, and Samuel. All examples in this article come from uncontested pre-exilic books.

¹³It is quite conceivable that the use of *kī* in poetry follows a different, but comparable, distribution (see e.g. Meyer 2001). In poetry it is often much less clear what the Common Ground contains, so the Common Ground may be a weaker factor in choosing between *kī* and alternatives in poetic texts.

¹⁴Naturally, there are cases that can be classified as one of two categories, in particular in the temporal/causal, temporal/conditional, and causal/resultative categories (cf. Locatell 2020). My argument does not rely on a sharp distinction between these categories, so I have in these cases selected what seemed to be the best-fitting category without spending too much thought on it.

¹⁵Gen. 8:21 (causal/concessive); 21:7 (adversative/standalone); 38:16c (conditional/resultative); 1 Sam. 15:24a (resultative/standalone); 2 Sam. 18:3b (causal *or* adversative, but not causal-adversative). See the data set for more details.

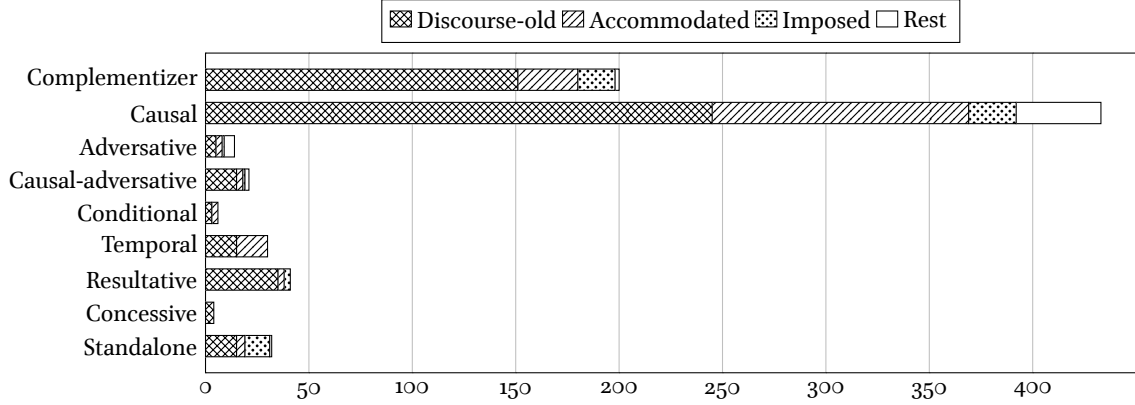


Figure 2: Types of reference to the Common Ground for each use type of $k\bar{i}$.

Type	Common Ground		Accommodated		Imposed		Rest		Total
Complementizer	151	76%	29	15%	18	9%	2	1%	200
Causal	245	57%	124	29%	23	5%	41	9%	433
Adversative	5	36%	3	21%	1	7%	5	36%	14
Causal-adversative	15	71%	3	14%	1	5%	2	10%	21
Conditional	3	50%	3	50%	0		0		6
Temporal	15	50%	15	50%	0		0		30
Resultative	35	85%	3	7%	3	7%	0		41
Concessive	4	100%	0		0		0		4
Standalone	15	47%	4	13%	12	38%	1	3%	32
Total	488	62%	184	24%	58	7%	51	7%	781
Ambiguous									5
In construction $k\bar{i}$ 'im or grammaticalized meaning 'except'									22
Grand total									808

Table 1: Distribution of instances of $k\bar{i}$ and the use of Common Ground per type.

hārā-tā

conceive\PFV-3F.SG

‘And he came into Hagar and she conceived, and she saw *that* she had conceived.’

The information can also be accommodated, as in (6), repeated here. In this example, the fact that the man cannot overpower Jacob is easily accommodated by the Addressee (the reader) given the information that they wrestle for a long time (until daybreak).

- (6) Gen. 32:25–26: וַיִּאָבֶק אִישׁ עִמּוֹ עַד עֹלֹת הַשָּׁחַר: וַיֵּרָא כִּי לֹא יָכֹל לְאָד אֶלֹתָיִם
way-y-ē’ābēq *is* *‘imm=ō* *‘ad* *‘ālōt* *has=šāhar*
 CONJ-3M-wrestle\PRET[SG] man with=him until go_up\INF.of the=daybreak
way-y-ar’ *kī* *lō’* *yākōl* *l=ō*
 CONJ-3M-see\PRET[SG] **COMP** not be_able\PFV[3M.SG] to=him
 ‘And a man wrestled with him until daybreak, and he realized *that* he could not overpower him.’

A comparison with other complementation strategies is most helpful to show that *kī*-clauses are associated with Common Ground; I will use רָאָה *rā’ā* ‘see’ as a running example. Complements of *rā’ā* can be (a) clauses introduced by *kī*, (b) clauses introduced by וְהִנֵּה *wə-hinnē* ‘and behold’, and (c) nominal phrases, often modified by an attributive participle.¹⁶ First, with *hinnē*, the information given in the complement clause is new and not anticipated by the Addressee. In (10), the Addressee is the reader:¹⁷

- (10) Gen. 22:13: וַיֵּשָׂא אַבְרָהָם אֶת־עֵינָיו וַיֵּרָא וְהִנֵּה־אֵיל אַחֵר נֹאֲחֵז בְּסִבְבָּד בְּקִרְיָנוּ
way-y-iššā’ *‘abrāhām* *’et* *‘en=āyw* *way-y-ar’* *wə=hinnē* *‘ayil*
 CONJ-3M-lift\PRET[SG] Abraham OBJ eye=DU.his CONJ-3M-see\PRET[SG] **and=behold** ram
‘ahar *ne’ēhaz* *b=as=sabak* *bə=qarn=āyw*
 behind hold\MID.PFV[3M.SG] in=the=bush in=horn=PL.its
 ‘As Abraham looked up, he saw—and behold!—a ram behind [him]; it had been caught with its horns in a bush.’

Second, when *rā’ā* has a nominal complement modified by an attributive participle ((11); cf. Isaksson 2009: 57–59), the information is typically new and unexpected (hence not easily accommodated), but also not marked as particularly noteworthy or immediately requiring the Addressee’s attention. This strategy thus provides a middle ground between complementation with *kī* on the one hand, and *hinnē* on the other. The strategy can also be combined with *hinnē* ‘behold’, in which case the information is noteworthy (12).

- (11) 2 Sam. 11:2: וַיֵּרָא אִשָּׁה רֹחֶצֶת מַעַל הַגָּג
way-y-ar’ *’iššā* *rōheš-et* *mē=’al* *hag=gāg*
 CONJ-3M-see\PRET[SG] woman bathe\PTCP-F.SG from=on the=roof
 ‘... and he saw a woman bathing from upon the roof.’
- (12) Gen. 18:2: וַיֵּשָׂא עֵינָיו וַיֵּרָא וְהִנֵּה שְׁלֹשָׁה אַנְשִׁים נֹצְבִים עָלָיו
way-y-iššā’ *‘en=āyw* *way-y-ar’* *wə=hinnē* *šəlōšā* *‘ānāš-īm*
 CONJ-3M-lift\PRET[SG] eye=DU.his CONJ-3M-see\PRET[SG] **and=behold** three man-PL
niššāb-īm *‘āl=āyw*
 stand\PTCP-M.PL on=him

¹⁶ As pointed out by a reviewer, strategy (b) is not syntactic but pragmatic in nature, but this does not preclude a comparison between the three. There are also some cases where the complement is introduced by an interrogative pronoun. In these cases the information content is evidently not known to the Speaker (e.g. Gen. 37:20: ‘and we’ll see *what* will become of his dreams!’), so I will not compare these instances to complementation with *kī* here.

¹⁷ Also Gen. 19:28; Jdg. 21:21. With a participle the complement can be either clausal or nominal: Gen. 18:2; 24:63; 26:8; 29:2; 37:25; Jdg. 3:24; 9:43; 1 Sam. 10:11; 2 Sam. 13:34. Two examples are ambiguous between participle and suffix conjugation (PFV): Gen. 33:1; 2 Sam. 18:24.

‘He lifted up his eyes and he saw—and behold!—three men were standing in front of him.’

Hinnē ‘behold’ also occurs with *kī*, but this combination is highly marked, because it suggests both noteworthy and discourse-old information status. In my corpus it occurs only once, in (13).¹⁸ Here, an angel tries to convince a woman who is barren that she will become pregnant. The angel has already said this once before, justifying the use of *kī*, but it remains a noteworthy fact that the woman will not have gotten used to yet, justifying the use of *hinnē*.

- (13) Jdg. 13:5: כִּי הִנֵּה הָרָה וְיִלְדֶת בֵּן
kī hinn=āk hārā wə-yōlad-t bēn
 COMP behold=you pregnant CONJ-bear\MOD-2F.SG son
 ‘(Behold, you are barren ... but you shall conceive ... So be careful ...) for behold, you are pregnant and shall bear a son.’

To sum up, *hinnē* ‘behold’ introduces discourse-new or noteworthy information, and *kī* introduces discourse-old or easily accommodated information. A nominal complement modified by an attributive participle, unless combined with *hinnē* ‘behold’, is used for information that is new and not expected, but also not particularly noteworthy. This division of labor supports the analysis that *kī* marks reference to the Common Ground.

3.2 Cognitive verbs

The class of cognitive verbs consists primarily of יָדָע *yāda* ‘know’ (72 times); other verbs in this class are נִחַם *niḥam* ‘regret’ (4 times), בִּין *bīn* ‘understand’ (twice), כִּחַד *kihēd* ‘hide’, and זָכַר *zākar* ‘remember’ (both once). All these less frequent predicates are factive and thus necessarily refer to Common Ground (e.g. 1 Sam. 15:35b: ‘I have come to regret (*niḥam*) that I have made Saul king’).

The verb *yāda* ‘know’ is often used in the same sense as *rā’ā* ‘see’, meaning ‘realize’, and then has a complement that is obviously discourse-old or accommodated by the Addressee. However, in my data set, *yāda* ‘know’ is used more frequently than *rā’ā* to impose information on the Common Ground, as in (8), repeated here:¹⁹

- (8) 1 Sam. 28:1: תִּדַּע כִּי אֶחָדִי תֵצֵא בְּמַחֲנֵה
t-ēda’ kī ’itt=ī t-ēṣē’ b=am=maḥāne
 2-know\IPFV[M.SG] COMP with=me 2-go_out\IPFV[M.SG] in=the=camp
 ‘(And Achish said to David:) “You should know ... that you will go out with me in battle.”’

As explained in section 1.2, Achish here uses *kī* to signal to David that no discussion is possible. The information content (that David will go out with him in battle) is imposed on the Common Ground and cannot be rejected. Apart from such cases of imposition, however, *kī*-clauses with cognitive verbs are quite similar to those with verbs of perception.

3.3 Speech verbs

The most frequent speech verb with *kī*-clauses is הִגִּיד *higgīd* ‘inform’ (13 times, and 5 times in the passive); we also have נִשְׁבַּע *nišba* ‘swear’ (2 times), and אָמַר *amar* ‘say’, בָּשַׂר *biššēr* ‘bring good news’, and

¹⁸Outside my corpus, *kī hinnē* only appears in prophetic texts: Isa. 3:1; 26:21; 60:2; 65:17, 18; 66:15; Jer. 1:15; 8:17; 25:29; 30:3, 10; 45:5; 46:27; 49:15; 50:9; Ezek. 30:9; Jbref369.

¹⁹Specifically, with *rā’ā* ‘see’, 45 examples refer to the Common Ground, of 15 the content can be accommodated, of 1 the content is imposed, and 2 are exceptional. With *yāda* ‘know’, 53 examples refer to the Common Ground, of 4 the content can be accommodated, of 13 the content is imposed, and none are exceptional.

וַיִּבְּאוּ אֶל-צִיִּיחַ בֵּית אֵל בְּרִית: וַיָּגֵד לְאַבְיִמֶלֶךְ כִּי הִתְקַבְּצוּ כָּל-בְּעָלֵי מְגִד־לִשְׁכָם: (1 time each).²⁰ It is noteworthy that *ʾamar* ‘say’, which is overall more frequent, is used so little with *kī*. This suggests a contrast between this verb and *higgīd* ‘inform’, wherein the latter is preferred when the complement is in the Common Ground. Thus, in the following example, the indirect speech complement repeats content that was already introduced to the reader in the previous sentence, and accordingly, *higgīd* ‘inform’ is used with *kī*.²¹

- (14) Jdg. 9:46–47: וַיָּבֹאוּ אֶל-צִיִּיחַ בֵּית אֵל בְּרִית: וַיָּגֵד לְאַבְיִמֶלֶךְ כִּי הִתְקַבְּצוּ כָּל-בְּעָלֵי מְגִד־לִשְׁכָם: *way-y-ābō-ū ʾel ʕarīah bēt ʾel bərīt way-y-uggad*
CONJ-3M-come\PRET-PL to stronghold.of house.of El Berith CONJ-3M-inform\PASS.PRET[SG]
la=ʾābīmelek kī hītā-qabbāṣ-ū kāl baʾāl-ē mīgādal šakem
to=Abimelech COMP REFL-gather\PLURACT.PFV-3PL all.of lord-PL.of tower.of Shechem
‘And [the leaders of the Tower of Shechem] came to the stronghold of the house of El-Berith. And Abimelech was informed *that* all the leaders of the tower of Shechem had gathered.’

A comparison with asyndetic indirect speech (Miller 2003: 119–123) is interesting here.²² It should be noted that asyndetic indirect speech only occurs embedded within direct speech (Miller 2003: 120), and the absence of a complementizer may therefore be attributed in part to register (cf. the more frequent omission of the English complementizer *that* in direct speech: Elsness 1984; Rissanen 1991). However, when we compare indirect speech with and without complementizer, both embedded in direct speech, a Common Ground effect can be observed, as in the following examples repeated from section 1.2:

- (3) Gen. 12:13: אֲמַרְיִנָּא אֶתְּחִי אִשָּׁתְּ *ʾimr-ī nā ʾāhōt=ī ʾatt*
say\IMP-F.SG please sister=mine you
‘(Abram said to his wife Sarai: “...) Please say Ø you are my sister.”’
- (4) Gen. 12:18: וַיִּקְרָא פַרְעֹה לְאַבְרָם וַיֹּאמֶר ... לָמָּה לֹא-הִגַּדְתָּ לִּי כִּי אִשְׁתִּי הִוא: *way-y-iqrā ʾpar ʾoh lā=ʾabrām way-y-ōmer ... lāmmā lōʾ*
CONJ-3M-call\PRET[SG] Pharaoh to=Abram CONJ-3M-say\PRET[SG] ... why not
higgad-tā l=ī kī ʾiš=akā hī
inform\PFV-2M.SG to=me COMP wife=yours she
‘So Pharaoh called Abram and said: “... Why did you not tell me *that* she is your wife?”’

The difference between these two cases is that in (3) the idea that Sarai should present herself as Abram’s sister is new to her, whereas in (4) the fact that she is Abram’s wife is known to Abram. This explains why *kī* is used in the second example but not in the first.²³

One could object that the pair in (3–4) is not minimal because two different verbs are used: *higgīd* ‘inform’ with *kī* in (4) and *ʾamar* ‘say’ without *kī* in (3). Since asyndetic indirect speech complements are only ever found with *ʾamar* ‘say’ (Miller 2003: 121), a better minimal pair cannot be given.²⁴ However, note that the simple fact that *kī* appears with one verb and not the other can and should be seen as

²⁰I follow Miller (2003: 103–116) in rejecting the idea, put forward by Budde (1889), Goldenberg (1991), and others, that *kī* can introduce direct speech: *kī* either introduces indirect speech, or it is the first word in the reported direct speech. I discuss cases of the former here; when *kī* is part of the reported speech it can have any other function, which I discuss throughout the rest of this article.

²¹Keep in mind here, again, that the Addressee, for our purposes, is not the Addressee of the speech event (the one who is being informed, here Abimelech), but the Addressee of the reporting of the speech event (i.e., the reader of the text).

²²Indirect speech can also be introduced with the relative pronoun אֲשֶׁר *ʾāšer* (Miller 2003: 97–98), but since this is rare and mostly a feature of Late Biblical Hebrew, I will not compare the two here.

²³In Gen. 12:19, Pharaoh continues to ask: ‘why did you say, “she is my sister”?’, without *kī*. But *kī* is excluded here since the complement is a direct speech report, as can be seen from the pronoun shift (Miller 2003: 120).

²⁴The one example of *ʾamar* ‘say’ with a *kī*-clause has the verb in the meaning ‘think, say to oneself’: ‘I *thought that* you really hated [your bride], so I gave her to your best man’ (Jdg. 15:2). Common Ground is imposed here; the Speaker informs the Addressee of an assumption he made based on the Addressee’s earlier behavior.

reflecting the function of the complementizer to mark Common Ground: meaning ‘inform’, *higgīd* is simply much more suitable to talk about common knowledge, whereas *āmar* ‘say’ is more often used in contexts where the Addressee is given new information, such as imperatives (3). This distribution therefore confirms the hypothesis concerning *kī*.

3.4 Miscellaneous complementation structures

Although complementizer *kī*-clauses are usually object clauses complementing verbs, they can also complement nouns and prepositions, or function as subject clauses. With nouns we only find *ēd* ‘witness’ (1 Sam. 12:5; Ruth 4:9) and *ēdā* ‘legal proof’ (Gen. 21:30b); with prepositions we only have *ad* ‘until’ (3 times).

The nouns *ēd* ‘witness’ and *ēdā* ‘legal proof’ are used with *kī* only to establish who can corroborate a certain fact. This is always a known fact, that is, a fact in the Common Ground:

- (15) 1 Sam. 12:5: וַיֹּאמֶר אֵלֵיהֶם עַד יְהוָה בָּכֶם ... כִּי לֹא מָצָאתֶם בְּיָדִי מִן־מָוֶה
way-y-ōmer ālē=hēm ēd yhw h bā=kēm ... kī lō māṣā-tēm
 CONJ-3M-say\PRET[SG] to=them witness Yahweh against=you ... COMP not find\PFV-2M.PL
bə=yād=ī mā’ūmā
 in=hand=mine anything

‘(And they said: “You have not wronged us ...”) So he said to them: “Yahweh is a witness against you ... *that* you have not found any [charge] against me.”’

Here, the complement clause simply reiterates what has already been said in the previous verse. Without *kī*, *ēd* ‘witness’ can be used with new information. In the following example, it is clear that Laban and Jacob are going to form some kind of covenant, but the preceding context provides no information based on which the Addressee can deduce that the cairn will be a marker of the border between them. Therefore *kī* would be inappropriate:

- (16) Gen. 31:52: וְעַד הַגֵּל הַזֶּה ... אִם־אֶנִּי לֹא־אֶעֱבֹר אֶל־יְדֵי הַגֵּל הַזֶּה וְאִם־אֶתָּה לֹא־תֵעָבֶר אֵלַי אֶת־הַגֵּל הַזֶּה ... לִרְעָה
ēd hag=gal haz=ze ... ’im ānī lō’ ’-ē’bōr ’ēl=kā ’et hag=gal
 witness the=cairn the=this ... if I not 1SG-pass_over\IPFV to=you OBJ the=cairn
haz=ze wə=’im ’attā lō’ t-a’ābōr ’ēla=y ’et hag=gal haz=ze ...
 the=this and=if you not 2-pass_over\IPFV[M.SG] to=me OBJ the=cairn the=this ...
lə=rā’ā
 for=evil

(Laban to Jacob:) “This cairn is a witness ...: Ø I will not pass this cairn to you, and you will not pass this cairn ... to me to do harm.”

Each instance with *ad* ‘until’ describes a direct consequence of the matrix clause (Gen. 26:13; 41:49; 2 Sam. 23:10). For example, in (17), being very wealthy is a direct consequence of becoming more and more wealthy. The *kī*-clause is therefore easily accommodated in the Common Ground:

- (17) Gen. 26:13: וַיֵּגְדַל הָאִישׁ וַיְהִי עַד כִּי־יִגְדַּל מְאֹד וַיֵּגְדַּל הָלוֹךְ וַיֵּלֶךְ הָאִישׁ
way-y-iḡdal hā=’iš way-y-ēlek hālōk wə=ḡāḏēl
 CONJ-3M-be_great\PRET[SG] the=man CONJ-3M-go\PRET[SG] go\INFABS and=be_great\PTCP[M.SG]
’ad kī ḡāḏal mā’ōd
 until COMP be_great\PFV[3M.SG] very

‘The man was wealthy, and he became more and more wealthy²⁵ to the point *that* he was very wealthy.’

²⁵Reading *ḡāḏōl* (INFABS) for *ḡāḏēl*, following the leading scholarly edition (Elliger & Rudolph 1997); for the durative interpretation of the infinitive absolute, see Gzella (2008).

The remaining cases are subject clauses. Two of these begin with *אִי אֵפֶן* *ʾap kī* ‘[it is] even [the case] that’ (Gen. 3:1; 1 Sam. 14:30). I first discuss the other four, which are more straightforward: they all nominalize a previously introduced proposition, and thus refer to the Common Ground (1 Sam. 25:30; 2 Sam. 9:1; 18:3; Ruth 2:22). For instance, in (18), the proposition in the *kī*-clause is implied by the earlier ‘you will not go out’:

- (18) 2 Sam. 18:3c: *לֹא תֵצֵא ... וְעַתָּה טוֹב בִּי־תִהְיֶה־לָנוּ מְעִיר לְעֹזֹר:*
lō’ t-ēṣē’ ... wə=‘attā tōb kī t-thayē lā=nū mē=‘īr
 not 2-go_out\IPFV[M.SG] ... and=now good COMP 2-be\IPFV[M.SG] for=us from=city
la=‘zōr
 for=help
 ‘(The king said to the people: “I myself will also go out with you.” But the people said:) “You will not go out ...; now, it is better *that* you provide support for us from the city.”’

These cases thus confirm the hypothesis that *kī* marks the use of Common Ground (unfortunately, however, they cannot be compared to asyndetic finite subject clauses; these do not exist).

The cases with *ʾap kī* ‘[it is] even [the case] that ...’ are as follows:²⁶

- (19) Gen. 3:1: *אֵפֶן כִּי יֹאמַר אֱלֹהִים לֹא תֹאכְלוּ מִכָּל עֵץ הַגָּן:*
ʾap kī ʾamar ʾēlōhīm lō’ t-ō’kəl-ū mik=kōl ʿeṣ hag=gān
 even COMP say\PFV[3M.SG] God not 2-eat\IPFV-M.PL from=all.of tree.of the=garden
 ‘(And the snake said to the woman:) “Is it *really* the case *that* God has said: ‘You shall not eat from any tree of the garden?’”’
- (20) 1 Sam. 14:30a: *אֵפֶן כִּי לֹא אָכַל אֶבֶל הַיּוֹם הָעֵם מִשְׁלַל אֲבִיּוֹ אֲשֶׁר מָצָא בִּי עֵתָה לֹא־רַבְתָּה מִכָּה בַּפְּלִשְׁתִּים:*
ʾap kī lū’ ʾākol ʾākal hayyōm hā=ʾām miš=šəlal
 even COMP had_not eat\INFABS eat\PFV[3M.SG] today the=army(M) from=provision.of
ʾoyəb=āyw ʾāšer māsā’ kī ʾattā lō’ rābā-tā makkā
 enemy=PL.its REL find\PFV[3M.SG] COMP now not be_great\PFV-3F.SG slaughter(F)
b=ap=palištī-m
 against=the=Philistine-PL
 ‘(See how my eyes gleamed when I tasted just a little of this honey.) It’s *certainly* the case *that*, had the army today eaten from the enemies’ provision which it found, that now the slaughter of the Philistines would have been greater.’

Example (19) is a case of information imposed on the Common Ground: the snake presumably knows that God has only forbidden the people to eat from one tree, but gains the woman’s trust by pretending he is asking a simple question. By pretending that he is ill-informed, the snake presents itself as harmless to the woman, which it will subsequently exploit. In (20), the information is accommodated in the Common Ground. In the previous clause, the Speaker has suggested that he was strengthened by eating just a little of the enemies’ provisions. This verse simply extends this to the rest of the army: if the whole army had eaten the honey, they would all have been strengthened, and so won more easily from the Philistines.²⁷

²⁶The construction *ʾap kī* can sometimes be read as ‘how much more/less’, introducing a clause that provides a stronger reason for an implicit assertion than the reason provided in the previous clause (Van der Merwe, Naudé & Kroeze 2017: §40.14.1b). Three cases where *ʾap kī* should be read together are classified as causal (1 Sam. 21:6b; 23:3; 2 Sam. 16:11a).

²⁷The second *kī* can be ignored for our purposes since this is the normal way to continue after a counterfactual clause; cf. Gen. 31:42, Gen. 43:10, and 2 Sam. 2:27b in (52) below.

3.5 Summary

In conclusion, both the distribution of complementizer *kī* over different matrix predicates and a comparison with other complementation strategies support the hypothesis that *kī* marks information in the Common Ground, or information that is easily accommodated in the Common Ground. In terms of distribution we may note the frequent use with רָאָה *rā'ā* in the sense ‘realize (old information)’ rather than the literal ‘see (something new)’, as well as the preference for הִגִּיד *higgīd* ‘inform (of old information)’ over אָמַר *āmar* ‘say (something new)’. I have compared *kī* to various other complementation strategies, such as וַהֲגִיד *wa-hinnē* ‘and behold’ and asyndetic indirect speech, which can all be shown to be used when the complement is not in the Common Ground yet, in contrast to the cases with *kī*. The following sections proceed with the analysis of circumstantial *kī*-clauses.

4 Causal *kī*

As mentioned in section 2, *kī* most frequently introduces a causal clause, which gives the cause, reason, or ground for the event described in the main clause.²⁸ I include here both “objective” causes (explaining why an event occurred) and “subjective” causes (explaining why a speaker makes an utterance); for the diachronic relationship between the three, see Locatell (2025). In the majority of cases (almost 90%), the cause given in the clause is either already in the Common Ground or easily accommodated by the Addressee. It is not uncommon for causal conjunctions to be sensitive to reference to Common Ground (see e.g. Dancygier & Sweetser 2000 on English *since*). Examples of such straightforward cases of causal *kī* are provided in (21–24). In (21), the reason is in the Common Ground, because it is cultural knowledge which the Speaker (writer) assumes the Addressee (reader) to have. In (22), the reason is in the Common Ground because it has been given in the previous clause.

- (21) Gen. 34:14: לֹא נוּכָל ... כִּי-תִתְּנָהּ הוּא לָנוּ:
lō' n-ūkal ... kī hērpā hī' lā=nū
 not 1PL-be_able\IPFV ... COMP disgrace it for=us
 ‘We cannot (do this, give our sister to a man who is uncircumcised), *for* it is a disgrace to us.’
- (22) Jdg. 14:17: וַתִּבֶּךְ עָלָיו שִׁבְעַת הַיָּמִים אֲשֶׁר-הָיָה לָהֶם הַמִּשְׁתָּה וַיְהִי בַיּוֹם הַשְּׁבִיעִי וַיַּגְדִּלָהּ כִּי הִצִּילָתָהּ:
wat-t-ēbk 'āl=āyw šib'a-t hay=yām-īm 'āšer hāyā lā=hem
 CONJ-F-cry\PRET[3SG] on=him seven-of the=day-PL REL be\PFV[3M.SG] for=them
ham=mište wa-y-ahī b=ay=yōm haš=šabī' way-y-agged
 the=party(M) CONJ-3M-be\PRET[SG] on=the=day the=seventh CONJ-3M-inform\PRET[SG]
l=āh kī hēšiq-at=hū
 to=her COMP press\PFV-3F.SG=him
 ‘She (Delilah) cried in his (Samson’s) presence during the seven days of their party, and on the seventh day he told her, *because* she pressed him so.’

In (23), it is said that the grain that Joseph is storing is ‘a very great quantity’, and eventually he has to stop counting it. Based on this, the information in the *kī*-clause (that the stored grain had become immeasurable) is easily accommodated. Similarly, in (24), Samuel has to take oil and go to Jesse. Based on this (and the fact that Saul has been rejected as a king in the preceding chapter), it is easily accommodated that someone in Jesse’s family will be the new king.

²⁸The discussion of causal-adversative *kī* is delayed until section 5, where adversative *kī* is discussed as well.

- (23) Gen. 41:49b: וַיִּצְבֹּר יוֹסֵף בָּר כְּחֹל הַיָּם הַרְבֵּה מֵאֵד עַד בִּיחְדָּל לִסְפֹּר כִּי־אֵין מִסְפָּר:
 way-y-iṣbōr yōsēp bār kə=hōl hay=yām harbe məʔōd ʾad
 CONJ-3M-store\PRET[SG] Joseph grain like=sand.of the=sea be_great\CAUS.INF very until
 kī ḥāḏal li=spōr kī ʾen mispār
 COMP stop\PFV[3M.SG] to=count\INF COMP not_exist number
 ‘And Joseph stored grain—as much as the sand of the sea, a very great quantity—to the point
 that he stopped counting it *because* it was immeasurable.’
- (24) 1 Sam. 16:1: מִלֵּא קֶרֶןךָ שֶׁמֶן וְלֵךְ אֶשְׁלַחְךָ אֶל־יִשָּׁי בֵּית־הַלְחָמִי כִי־רָאִיתִי בְּבָנָיו לִי מֶלֶךְ:
 mallēʾ qarn=akā šemen wə=lēk ʾ-əšəldāḥ=ākā ʾel yišay
 fill\IMP[M.SG] horn=yours oil and=go\IMP[M.SG] 1SG-send_out\IPFV=you.OBJ to Jesse
 bēt hallahmī kī rāʾī-tī bə=bān=āyw l=ī melek
 the_Bethlehemite COMP see\PFV-1SG in=son=PL.his for=me king
 ‘Fill your horn with oil and go, I will send you to Jesse the Bethlehemite, *for* I have seen a king for
 me amongst his sons.’

Things become more interesting in cases where something is imposed on the Common Ground. In the following example, David has just sneaked into Saul’s camp while Abner was on guard. David then says to Abner that he could have killed Saul. Using *kī*, David suggests that Abner must know that an enemy soldier (David himself) came into the camp, thus emphasizing that Abner did not do a very good job protecting Saul.

- (25) 1 Sam. 26:15: וְלָמָּה לֹא שָׁמַרְתָּ אֶל־אֲדֹנֶיךָ הַמֶּלֶךְ כִּי־בָא אֶחָד הָעָם לְהַשְׁחִית אֶת־הַמֶּלֶךְ אֲדֹנֶיךָ:
 wə=lāmmā lōʾ šāmar-tā ʾel ʾədōne=kā ham=melek kī bāʾ ʾahad
 and=why not guard\PFV-2M.SG to lord=yours the=king COMP come\PFV[3M.SG] one.of
 hāʾ=ām lə=hašhīt ʾet ham=melek ʾədōne=kā
 the=army to=destroy\INF OBJ the=king lord=yours
 ‘And why haven’t you protected your lord the king, *given that* a soldier came to kill the king your lord?’

In each of the examples in (21–25), the Speaker positions a sentential complement close to the Addressee using [+distal] *kī*. Depending on the context, this can have several effects: it may signal to the Addressee that discourse-old information is being referenced (21–22), or the Addressee may be prompted to accommodate some new information in the Common Ground (23–24), or the Speaker may present information as something the Addressee should have known, knowing full well that they do not (25).

As further evidence for the fact that causal *kī* marks Common Ground, it is interesting to see that when a cause consists of partially new information, the new information can be introduced by *wə-hinnē* ‘and behold’. In (26), the theory correctly predicts that *wə-hinnē* should be used instead of mere *ʾ wə* ‘and’, because it is needed to separate discourse-old from discourse-new information.

- (26) Jdg. 18:9: קוּמָה וְנַעֲלָה עֲלֵיהֶם כִּי רָאִינוּ אֶת־הָאָרֶץ וְהִנֵּה טוֹבָה מְאֹד:
 qūm-ā wə=n-aʾāle ʾāle=hem kī rāʾī-nū ʾet hāʾ=ʾāreš
 stand_up\IMP-M.SG and=1PL-go_up\IPFV to=them COMP see\PFV-1PL OBJ the=land(F)
 wə=hinnē ṭōb-ā məʔōd
 and=behold good-F.SG very
 ‘(And the Danites returned to their brothers in Zorah and Eshtaol, and their brothers said to them: “How did it go?” And they said:) “Come on, let’s go up against them, *for* we saw their land, *and look*: it’s very good!”’

4.1 Backgrounded causal clauses

There are, however, cases of causal *kī* where Common Ground is not being referred to or even imposed. Here the original [+distal] feature of *kī* is often still relevant. There are plenty of cases where the cause is backgrounded, and in that sense placed at a distance from the main topic of conversation. Quite often the *kī*-clause provides the reason for a positive or negative command (16 out of 39 cases without reference to Common Ground), as in the following examples:²⁹

- (27) Jdg. 13:5b: וּמוֹרָה לֹא־יָעִלָּה עַל־רֹאשׁוֹ כִּי־נָזִיר אֱלֹהִים יִהְיֶה הַנָּעַר מִן־הַבֶּטֶן
ū=mōrā lō' y-a'āle 'al rōš=ō kī nāzīr 'ēlōhūm
 and=razor(M) not 3M-go_up\IPFV[SG] on head=his COMP dedicated.of God
y-ihye han=na'ar min hab=bāṭen
 3M-be\IPFV[SG] the=boy from the=womb
 '(Look, you are pregnant and will give birth to a son,) but a razor shall not come on his head, *for* the boy will be dedicated to God from the womb.'

- (28) Gen. 43:16: הָבֵא אֶת־הָאֲנָשִׁים הַבְּיֹתָהּ וּטְבַח טֶבֶח וְהָכֵן כִּי אֶתִּי יֹאכְלוּ הָאֲנָשִׁים בְּצֹהֲרַיִם
hābē' 'et hā=ānāš-īm hab=bāyāt-ā ū=təbōaḥ tēbaḥ
 bring\IMP[M.SG] OBJ the=man-PL the=house-ALL and=slaughter\IMP[M.SG] animal
wə=hāḱēn kī 'itt=ī y-ō'kəl-ū hā=ānāš-īm b=aš=šāhā'āyīm
 and=prepare\IMP[M.SG] COMP with=me 3M-eat\IPFV-PL the=man-PL at=the=noon
 'Bring the men to the house and slaughter an animal and prepare it, *for* the men will eat with me at noon.'

In such cases, the *kī*-clause provides an explanation, but it is most important to the Speaker that the command is followed. For this reason, the explanation in the causal clause can be backgrounded and hence marked with [+distal] *kī*. In the remaining cases, the *kī*-clause often provides information that is not crucial for the main story line and can therefore be seen as backgrounded as well.³⁰

4.2 Bleached causal meaning

Ten causal uses remain unexplained: they introduce clauses whose content is not in the Common Ground, easily accommodated, imposed, or backgrounded.³¹ In (29), for example, it is not known to the Addressee (the reader) that Rebekah is barren, nor is there any reason why it should be easily accommodated. However, the information is not backgrounded either, since it is picked up at the end of the verse: 'and Rebekah his wife conceived'.

- (29) Gen. 25:21: וַיַּעֲבֹר יִצְחָק לְיִהוָה לְנִכַח אִשְׁתּוֹ כִּי עֲקָרָה הִוא
way-y-ē'tar yiṣḥāq l=yhwh lanōkaḥ 'išt=ō kī 'āqār-ā hī'
 CONJ-3M-pray\PRET[SG] Isaac to=Yahweh on_behalf_of wife=his COMP barren-F.SG she
 'And Isaac prayed to Yahweh on behalf of his wife, *since* she was barren (, and God heard his prayer and Rebekah his wife conceived.)'

These ten examples thus require an explanation that is not based on a reinterpretation of the [+distal] feature. One possibility is that the [+distal] feature has bleached away in some causal uses, so that *kī* became usable as a general causal connective. There is a clear developmental path for such bleaching to

²⁹In the data set these are marked as "command". Positive commands: Gen. 21:12; 31:12; 40:15a; 43:16; 1 Sam. 14:39a; 16:11; 23:27; Ruth 3:18a. Negative commands: Gen. 2:17; 21:17; 26:24; 35:17; Jdg. 13:5b; 1 Sam. 4:20; 16:7a; 2 Sam. 13:32a.

³⁰In the data set these are marked as "backgrounded": Gen. 5:24; 10:25; 15:16; 21:16; 42:4; Jdg. 4:3; 16:17; 1 Sam. 20:26a; 30:12; 2 Sam. 13:2; 14:15; Ruth 1:6a; 3:17. Alternatively, these examples can be assumed to involve a bleached causal meaning, as discussed in the following subsection.

³¹In the data set these are marked as "bleached", for reasons explained below: Gen. 25:21; 37:17; Jdg. 6:30ab; 1 Sam. 4:13; 6:19a; 13:19; 30:6a; 2 Sam. 6:6; 19:27a.

have occurred. In an earlier stage of the language, there were only causal instances that are derived from a [+distal] feature (such as examples (21–28) discussed here). Speakers then reanalyzed *kī* as a general marker of causation. This enabled the spread to cases where the [+distal] feature does not seem to be interpretable any more, such as (29).

Note that the causal use is the most frequent by far, and is therefore most likely to show such semantic bleaching, on the basis of causal uses that do refer to Common Ground. In the data summary in section 2 it can be seen that exceptions in circumstantial uses of *kī* are limited to causal, causal-adversative, and adversative interpretations. It is noteworthy that there are no exceptions whatsoever in conditional, temporal, resultative, and concessive uses, while they are together twice as frequent than causal-adversative and adversative, which do have exceptions. The lack of exceptions in conditional, temporal, resultative, and concessive uses can therefore not be explained by their lower overall frequency. Instead, the distribution suggests that exceptions first arose due to semantic bleaching in the most frequent causal use, which enabled the spread to the closely related causal-adversative and adversative uses through semantic shift.

A critic might argue that if we need to assume semantic bleaching to have occurred for some cases anyway, it is simpler to describe the causal meaning of *kī* as bleached in all instances, including when the [+distal] feature is interpretable. On such a view, the fact that the *kī*-clauses in (21–28) express information that is already in the Common Ground, or is easily accommodated/imposed, is accidental. This argument cannot be maintained. First of all, this alternative is not, in fact, simpler, since reinterpretation of a [+distal] feature is independently needed to explain other circumstantial interpretations in sections 5 and 6 below, and there is no reason why a causal interpretation should not be pragmatically inferred as well. Furthermore, this alternative approach cannot account for the distribution of *kī*. Only 2% of the total number of causal *kī*-clauses is exceptional like (29). A quick look at a dictionary (e.g., Clines 1993–2011; Köhler et al. 2001) shows that this is a much smaller portion of the data than is the case with other causal conjunctions (e.g., *ʔi ya'an*). Similarly it can be shown that *kī* is much more frequent with commands than other causal conjunctions. These distributional facts can only be explained if *kī* does not simply have a bleached causal meaning, but if many of the causal instances of *kī* are in fact pragmatically inferred from the general meaning of referring to Common Ground.

5 Adversative and causal-adversative *kī*

An adversative clause provides a contrast. The following example refers back to 1 Sam. 8:19, where the people asked for the second time for a king, after Samuel advised against their first request (1 Sam. 8:5, 10–18). The request is discourse-new in 1 Sam. 8:5, and hence made without *kī* there. In (30), Samuel quotes the second request, and *kī* is used; it thus marks the Common Ground status of the request when it is made for the second time.³² Since the people already asked for a king before, this request is in the Common Ground and here marked by *kī*:

- (30) 1 Sam. 10:19: וַתֹּאמְרוּ לוֹ כִּי-מֶלֶךְ תִּשָּׂא עָלֵינוּ
wat-t-ō'mər-ū lō kī meleḵ t-āšim ʿālē=nū
 CONJ-2M-say\PRET-PL no³⁴ COMP king 2M-appoint\IPFV[SG] over=us
 'But you said: "no; *but* you shall appoint a king over us!"'

I classified cases where the contrasting clause provides the reason or cause for a preceding negative statement as causal-adversative. Here again, the circumstantial clause is in the Common Ground, because its propositional content has already been introduced in the preceding verse:

³²In 1 Sam. 8:19 the second request is made with *kī ʾim*, a grammaticalized construction which I exclude in this study (see section 2). Here and in 1 Sam. 12:12b (1e), the second request is paraphrased and plain *kī* is used. Ruth 1:10 is similar: 'But we will return with you to your people!'

³⁴Reading אֵל *lō* 'no' for לוֹ *lō* 'to him' on the basis of other manuscripts and ancient translations; see Elliger & Rudolph (1997).

- (31) Gen. 45:8: לֹא־אַתֶּם שְׁלַחְתֶּם אֵתִי הִנֵּה כִּי הָאֱלֹהִים
 lō' 'attem śəlah-tē ʾōt=ī hēnnā kī hā=ʾēlōhūm
 not you send\PFV-2M.PL OBJ=me here COMP the=god
 'It is not you who have sent me here, *but/because* [it is] the deity.'

A comparison with other adversative strategies again shows that the degree of reference to Common Ground is especially high when *kī* is used. When the adversative clause presents new information, we often find the more neutral conjunction *wə* 'and, but, ...' instead:³⁵

- (32) Gen. 2:16–17: מִכָּל עֵץ־הַגָּן אָכַל תֹּאכַל: וּמֵעֵץ הַדְּעִת טוֹב וְרָע לֹא תֹאכַל מִמֶּנּוּ
 mik=kōl ʿēš hag=gān ʾākōl t-ōʾkēl ū=mē=ʿēš
 from=all.of tree.of the=garden eat\INFABS 2-eat\IPFV[M.SG] and=from=tree.of
 had=daʿat tōb wā=rāʿ lō' t-ōʾkal mimmen=nū
 the=knowledge.of good and=evil not 2-eat\IPFV[M.SG] from=it
 'You may eat from all the trees of the garden, *but* from the tree of the knowledge of good and evil you may not eat.'

A more marked way to introduce an adversative clause with new information content is to use *raq* 'however, but'.³⁶ In the following example, the *raq*-clause provides information that is not yet in the Common Ground:

- (33) Exod. 8:24: אֲנֹכִי אֲשַׁלְּחֶךָ לְאֶתְרִיּוֹ לֵלֶכֶת ... רַק הָרַחֵק לֹא־תִרְחִיקוּ
 ʾānōkī ʾ-āšallah ʾet=kem ... **raq** harhēq lō' t-arhīq-ū
 I 1SG-send_away\IPFV OBJ=you ... **however** be_far\CAUS.INFABS not 2-be_far\CAUS.IPFV-M.PL
 lā=leket
 to=go\INF
 'I will let you go ..., *however*, be sure not to go very far.'

Though most instances of adversative and causal-adversative *kī* make reference to the Common Ground, both categories are characterized by a relatively high number of instances that cannot be explained using a [+distal] feature. In both adversative (34) and causal-adversative (35), the *kī*-clause provides information that is not easily accommodated and cannot be seen as backgrounded either:

- (34) Jdg. 1:19a: וַיִּרֶשׁ אֶת־הַהָר כִּי לֹא לְהוֹרִישׁ אֶת־יִשְׂבֵּי הָעֵמֶק
 way-y-ōreš ʾet hā=hār kī lō' la=hōrīš ʾet yōšəb-ē
 CONJ-3M-conquer\PRET[SG] OBJ the=hill COMP not to=conquer\INF OBJ inhabit\PTCP-M.PL.of
 hā=ʿemeq
 the=plain
 'And [Judah] conquered the hill country, *but* they could not conquer the people living in the plains ...'

³⁵Simply searching for "but" in an English translation yields many more examples where *wə* introduces new information (e.g. Gen. 6:8, 18; 8:9).

³⁶However, *ʾak* 'indeed, just, only, but' regularly refers to discourse-old information content when used adversatively (see Levinsohn 2011: 92–94 for contexts where adversative *ʾak* is used to emphasize a previously introduced point). Though *ʾak* has cognates in Tigré and Ge'ez, I am not aware of a widely accepted etymology. It is tempting to associate this particle, like *kī*, with **ka*, but this is not necessary: the existence of some other particles sensitive to the contents of the Common Ground is not in itself problematic for my hypothesis.

- (35) Gen. 24:3–4: לֹא־תִקַּח אִשָּׁה לְבָנִי מִבְּנוֹת הַכְּנַעֲנִי אֲשֶׁר אֲנִי יוֹשֵׁב בְּקֶרְבָּן: כִּי אֶל־אֶרֶץ וְאֶל־מוֹלַדְתִּי תִלְךָ וְלִקְחָתָּ אִשָּׁה לְבָנִי
- lō' t-iqqah 'iššā li=bn=ī mib=bən-ōt hak=kəna'ānī 'āšer*
 not 2-take\IPFV[M.SG] woman for=son=mine from=child-F.PL.of the=Canaanite REL
'ānōkī yōšēb bə=qirb=ō kī 'el 'arš=ī wə='el mōladt=ī
 I live\PTCP[M.SG] in=midst=its COMP to land=mine and=to motherland=mine
t-ēlēk wə-lāqah-tā 'iššā li=bn=ī
 2-go\IPFV[M.SG] CONJ-take\MOD-2M.SG woman for=son=mine
- ‘You must not acquire a wife for my son from the women of the Canaanites among whom I am living, *but/because* you must (instead) go to my country and my motherland to take a wife for my son’

These cases are therefore exceptional in the same way as causal (29) above. As with causal *kī*, a diachronic account remains necessary for these cases. Given the relatively low number of occurrences of both adversative and causal-adversative *kī*, it is unlikely that these functions developed directly from the general meaning of *kī*, through a process of semantic bleaching similar to that proposed for causal uses in section 4.2. It is more likely that they are the result of a semantic shift, starting out with the already bleached causal meaning. It is easy to see how a causal meaning could expand to causal-adversative, and eventually lose the necessarily causal interpretation to become plain adversative; such a development is also attested in unrelated languages (cf. Kuteva et al. 2019: 84 and references therein; for discussion of this development in Biblical Hebrew, see Locatell 2017: 247–248 and references therein). In my corpus, bleached meanings are needed for 10 exceptional cases of causal *kī*, 2 cases of causal-adversative *kī*, and 5 cases of adversative *kī*.³⁷

6 Remaining circumstantial uses

Having discussed causal and adversative *kī*-clauses in sections 4 and 5, respectively, this section reviews the evidence of the remaining, lower-frequency types of circumstantial clauses introduced by *kī*: temporal and conditional clauses (section 6.1), resultative clauses (section 6.2), and concessive clauses (section 6.3). In all these types of circumstantial clauses, the information provided in the *kī*-clause is already in the Common Ground or easily accommodated, or (rarely) imposed on the Common Ground. There are no exceptions, and there will therefore be no need to assume that any of these uses of *kī* are bleached, as expected given the low frequency of these categories. All instances can be derived synchronically from a [+distal] feature.

6.1 Temporal and conditional clauses

In my corpus only few instances of *kī* are temporal, and even less conditional.³⁸ As is the case in many languages, the distinction is not always clear-cut, as seen in (36). For this reason, I will discuss them together.

- (36) Gen. 32:18: וַיֹּצֵא אֶת־הָרִאשׁוֹן לְאֶמֶר כִּי יִפְגְּשֶׁךָ עֵשָׂו
- wa-y-ašaw 'et hā=ri'šōn lē='mōr kī y-ipəgāš=kā*
 CONJ-3M-command\PRET[SG] OBJ the=first to=say\INF COMP 3M-meet\IPFV[SG]=you.OBJ
'ēšāw
 Esau
- ‘He (Jacob) commanded the first [servant], saying, “*If/When* Esau meets you, ...”’

³⁷These are marked as “bleached” in the data set. For the causal cases, see section 4.2. Causal-adversative cases are Gen. 17:15 and 24:4; adversative cases are Gen. 40:14; Jdg. 1:19a; 4:9a; 1 Sam. 15:35a; 2 Sam. 17:11.

³⁸This low frequency may be due to the narrative genre of my corpus (cf. Locatell 2017: 252 n. 322; most of his conditional examples are from legal texts, which I did not include in my corpus).

There are two ways in which *kī* interacts with Common Ground in such cases. First, temporal and conditional clauses introduced by *kī* always describe an event that the Speaker considers certain or likely to occur or have occurred. *Kī* is not used for conditions that the Speaker does not expect to be met, or events that are unlikely to occur or have occurred. By modifying a main clause *M* with a conditional *C*, the Speaker can enlarge the Common Ground: roughly, to utter *M if C* is to say that *M* could be uttered under the assumption that, in addition to the Common Ground, the condition stated in *C* is met. However, *kī* can only be used when this augmentation is reasonable given the current Common Ground: it should be easy to accommodate *C* (this is the case when it is likely or expected to occur or have occurred), or the Common Ground should already entail *C* (this is the case when it is certain to occur or have occurred). Second, in most occurrences, the event or condition described is also already salient in the surrounding discourse, and in that sense tracked by both Speaker and Addressee: it is under discussion, even if it is not certain that the condition is met.

Concretely, the first observation means that when *kī* introduces a conditional clause, it describes reasonably realistic conditions: it describes conditions that are likely to happen. In that sense, these conditional uses are much like the temporal uses of *kī*, and unlike the more general conditional use of אִם *im* ‘if’. This particle is used more frequently when it is truly uncertain whether a condition will be met. Thus, *kī* and *im* behave similarly to English *when* and *if*, respectively. This can be seen in the following example with *im*, where it is indeed uncertain for Speaker (and Addressee) whether the condition will be met:

- (37) Gen. 18:26: אִם-אֶמְצָא בְּסָדֶם חֲמִישִׁים צְדִיקִים בְּתוֹךְ הָעִיר וְנִשְׁאַתִּי לְכָל-הַמָּקוֹם בְּעִבּוּרָם
im ^{’-emṣā’} *bi=sdōm* *ḥāmišš-ūm* *ṣaddīq-im* *bə=tōk* *hā=’ir*
 if 1SG-find\IPFV in=Sodom five-PL righteous-PL in=middle.of the=city
wə-nāšā’-tī *lə=kāl* *ham=māqōm* *ba=’ābūr=ām*
 CONJ-forgive\MOD-1SG for=whole.of the=place for=sake=theirs
 ‘If I find at Sodom fifty righteous in the city, I will forgive the whole place for their sake.’

This can also be seen in the fact that when *kī* and *im* are combined, *kī* introduces a general condition, while *im* introduces a more specific condition (Van der Merwe, Naudé & Kroeze 2017: §40.11(1a)). In such a construction, the condition in the *kī*-clause is more likely to be met than the condition in the *im*-clause:

- (38) Lev. 1:2–3: אִם-עֲלָה קָרְבָּנוֹ אִם-עָלָה קָרְבָּנוֹ: אֶת-קָרְבָּנֶיכֶם: מִן-הַבְּקָר וּמִן-הַצֹּאן תִּקְרִיבוּ
ādām kī *y-aqrīb* *mikk=em* *qārbān* *l=yhwh* *min* *hab=bəhēmā min*
 man COMP 3M-present\IPFV[SG] from=you offering to=Yahweh from the=animals from
hab=bāqār ū=min *haš=šō’n* *t-aqrīb-ū* *’et* *qārbān=kem* *im* *ōlā*
 the=herd or=from the=flock 2-present\IPFV-M.PL OBJ offering=yours if burnt_offering
qārbān=ō *min* *hab=bāqār* *zākār* *tāmūm* *y-aqrīb=ennū*
 offering=his from the=herd male perfect 3M-present\IPFV[SG]=it.OBJ
 ‘If/When (*kī*) a man amongst you brings a sacrifice to Yahweh, you must bring your offer from the animals of the herd or the flock. If (*im*) it is a burnt offering from the herd, he shall offer a male without blemish.’

This fits with the general meaning described for *kī* above: the circumstantial clause does not introduce entirely unexpected information, but only information which is already expected, or at least easily accommodated given the Common Ground. In (36) above, with *kī*, Jacob’s servant is going towards Esau and will therefore surely meet him, while in (37), with *im*, it is not certain at all that there will be fifty righteous at Sodom. In (38), not all sacrifices are burnt offerings, so the condition in the *im*-clause is met in a subset of the worlds in which the condition in the *kī*-clause is met (therefore *im*, unlike *kī*, can here not be translated as ‘when’).

Temporal clauses with future reference time can be seen as an extreme case of such “expected conditionals”: they are, in a way, conditionals of which the condition is certain to be met at some future point in time:

- (39) Gen. 31:49: יִצְחָק יְהוָה בֵּינִי וּבֵינֶךָ כִּי נִסְתָּר אִישׁ מֵרֵעֵהוּ
y-iṣēp yhw h bēn=ī ū=bēn=ekā kī n-issāṭēr ṯš
 3M-guard\JUSS[SG] Yahweh between=me and=between=you COMP 1PL-hide\MID.IPFV one
mē=rē=ēhū
 from=companion=his
 ‘May Yahweh watch between me and you *when* we are hidden from each other.’

Temporal clauses with past reference time are similar. They require the described event to have occurred; *kī* cannot be used, for example, for counterfactuals, which are typically marked by לוּ *lū* ‘if only’.³⁹ As the examples below show, temporal *kī*-clauses are often preceded by *wayahī* ‘and it was’ (40–42,44), but this is not always the case (43).⁴⁰ In several cases, a *kī*-clause with past reference time is frequentative (i.e., it refers to multiple moments in time; cf. English ‘whenever’), as in (40). This is only contextually inferred, however, and not contributed by *kī*, as this interpretation is not always available (41):⁴¹

- (40) Jdg. 1:28: וַיְהִי כִי־חִזַּק יִשְׂרָאֵל וַיִּשֶׁם אֶת־הַכְּנַעֲנִי לְמַסַּ וְהוֹרִישׁ לֹא הוֹרִישׁ
wa-y-ahī kī ḥāzaq yiśrā’ēl way-y-āśem ’et
 CONJ-3M-be\PRET[SG] COMP be_strong\PFV[3M.SG] Israel CONJ-3M-put\PRET[SG] OBJ
hak=kāna’ānī lā=mas wə=hōrēš lō’ hōrīš=ō
 the=Canaanite to=forced_labor but=conquer\INFABS not conquer\PFV[3M.SG]=it.OBJ
 ‘And *whenever* Israel was strong they would put the Canaanites to work, but they did not totally conquer them.’
- (41) Gen. 27:1: וַיְהִי כִי־זָקֵן יִצְחָק ... וַיִּקְרָא אֶת־עֵשָׂו בְּנֹ הַגָּדֹל
wa-y-ahī kī zāqēn yiṣḥāq ... way-y-iqrā’ ’et ’ēśāw
 CONJ-3M-be\PRET[SG] COMP be_old\PFV[3M.SG] Isaac ... CONJ-3M-call\PRET[SG] OBJ Esau
bān=ō hag=gāḏōl
 son=his the=big
 ‘And *when* Isaac was old ..., he called Esau, his oldest son.’

To return to the second way in which temporal and conditional *kī* interacts with Common Ground: in most instances of temporal or conditional *kī*, the event or condition described in the circumstantial clause is already salient in the surrounding discourse, and in that sense tracked by both Speaker and Addressee. Consider:

³⁹Note that a counterfactual, like a temporal or conditional clause, can be described as augmenting the Common Ground. The only difference is that a counterfactual augments the Common Ground with information known to be false. If *kī* were simply described as *augmenting* the Common Ground, there would be no way to exclude a counterfactual interpretation. But since *kī* is [+distal] and therefore marks information that is in the Common Ground or at least easily accommodated, a counterfactual interpretation is excluded.

⁴⁰For arguments against analyzing *kī* in *wayahī kī* as a complementizer/nominalizer (i.e., ‘and it was *that*’ instead of ‘and it was *when*’), see Locatell (2017: 236–237). There does not appear to be a difference in the contribution of *kī* when preceded by וַיְהִי *wa-hāyā* ‘and it will be’ or וַיְהִי *wa-yahī* ‘and it was’, compared to when *kī* stands alone. The contribution of these temporal markers can be seen as shifting the reference time (e.g. Van der Merwe, Naudé & Kroeze 2017: §40.24–25) independent from the discursive contribution made by *kī*.

⁴¹A frequentative interpretation is also possible in Jdg. 2:18a; 12:5; 16:16; 2 Sam. 6:13; and we have a durative interpretation (referring to a longer stretch of time; cf. English ‘while’) in 1 Sam. 1:2; 17:48. Such interpretations are excluded in Gen. 6:1; 26:8; 31:37; 43:21; 44:24; Jdg. 6:5, 7; 8:1; 1 Sam. 14:29b; 22:22a; 2 Sam. 4:10, 11; 7:1, 12; 19:26.

- (42) Gen. 44:24: וַיְהִי כִּי עָלִינוּ אֶל-עַבְדְּךָ אָבִי
 wa-y-əhī kī ʾālī-nū ʾel ʾabd=əḵā ʾāb=ī
 CONJ-3M-be\PRET[SG] COMP go_up\PFV-1PL to servant=yours father=mine
 'And *when* we went up to your servant my father, ...'
- (43) Jdg. 2:16–18: וַיִּקֶּם יְהוָה שׁוֹפְטִים ... וַיְבַרְכֵם יְהוָה לְהֵם שׁוֹפְטִים
 way-y-āqem yhw h šōpəṭ-īm ... wə=kī hēqūm yhw h
 CONJ-3M-establish\PRET[SG] Yahweh judge-PL ... and=COMP establish\PFV[3M.SG] Yahweh
 lā=həm šōpəṭ-īm
 for=them judge-PL
 'And Yahweh established judges ... *Whenever* Yahweh established judges for them, (Yahweh would be with the judge ...)'
- (44) 1 Sam. 14:27–29b: וַיָּשָׁב יְדוֹ אֶל-פִּי וַתֵּאָרְנָה⁴² עֵינָיו ... אָרוּ עֵינָי כִּי טַעַמְתִּי מֶעֶט דְּבַשׁ הַזֶּה:
 way-y-āšəb yād=ō ʾel pī=w wat-t-āʾor-ənā
 CONJ-3M-return\CAUS.PRET[SG] hand=his to mouth=his CONJ-F-light_up\PRET-3PL
 ʿen=āyw ... ʾor-ū ʿen-ay kī ṭāʾam-tī mʾaṭ dābaš
 eye(F)=DU.his ... light_up\PFV-3PL eye-DU.mine COMP taste\PFV-1SG little.of honey
 haz=zə
 the=this
 'And [Jonathan] returned his hand to his mouth and his eyes lit up. (So a soldier spoke up and said, "Your father swore the army, saying, 'Cursed is the man who eats anything today'" (...). But Jonathan said: "My father has brought misfortune on the land. See that) my eyes lit up *when* I tasted a little of this honey!"

In (42), it is clear from the context to Joseph (the Addressee) that his brothers (the Speaker) have been to their father. It is therefore assumed to be part of the Common Ground, and *kī* can be used to refer to this event. In (43) this is even clearer, as the fact that Yahweh established judges has been introduced just a few sentences before. Example (44) is similar: the event described by the *kī*-clause is introduced in v. 27, and v. 28 (only given in translation) shows that the Addressee (the soldier) is aware of it as well.

To conclude this subsection: there are two ways in which temporal and conditional *kī*-clauses interact with the Common Ground. As we just saw, in many cases the event or condition is already tracked by both the Speaker and the Addressee, independent of whether it is likely to occur or have occurred. More importantly, however, in all instances the event or condition is certain or likely to occur or have occurred. As a result, if the event or condition is not yet in the Common Ground, it is at least easily accommodated. In this way these cases support the hypothesis about the general discursive contribution of *kī*.

6.2 Resultative clauses

Resultative clauses (sometimes called "consequential clauses") describe the result of the event described in the matrix clause; in English, resultative *kī* can often be translated with (*so*) *that*. When the result is also the purpose for a volitional act described in the matrix clause, a resultative clause is quite similar to a causal clause:

⁴²Consonantal text: וַתֵּאָרְנָה wat-t-irʿ-nā CONJ-3F-see\PRET-PL 'and [his eyes] saw'. I follow the reading of the vocalized text, which was standardized in the Middle Ages and is here corroborated by various manuscripts and ancient translations (Elliger & Rudolph 1997).

- (45) Gen. 31:36: מָה חָטָאתִי כִּי דָלַקְתָּ אַחֲרַי: *mah haṭṭā'-tī kī dālaq-tā 'ahār=āy*
 what sin\PFV-1SG COMP chase\PFV-2M.SG behind=me
 'How have I (Jacob) sinned *that* you (Laban) have chased after me?'

In (45), it is in the Common Ground that the Addressee chased after the Speaker, as the Addressee has just caught up with the Speaker when (45) is uttered. Note that there is no reason why a purpose or resultative clause in general should refer to a result in the Common Ground, as the following example with another resultative connective, לְמַעַן *lama'an*, shows:

- (46) Gen. 37:22: וַיֹּאמֶר אֲלֵהֶם | רְאוּבֵן אֶל־תִּשְׁפֹּכוּ דָם הַשְׂלִיכוּ אֹתוֹ אֶל־הַבּוֹר הַזֶּה אֲשֶׁר בְּמִדְבָּר וַיֵּד אֶל־תִּשְׁלַחֲוּ בּוֹ: *way-y-ō'mer 'ālē=hem rə'ūbēn 'al t-išpāk-ū dām hašlīk-ū*
 CONJ-3M-say\PRET[SG] to=them Reuben not 2-shed\JUSS-M.PL blood throw\IMP-M.PL
 'ōt=ō 'el hab=bōr haz=ze 'āšer b=am=midbār wə=yāḏ 'al t-išlah-ū
 OBJ=him to the=pit the=this REL in=the=desert but=hand not 2-send\JUSS-M.PL
 b=ō *lama'an haššil 'ōt=ō miy=yāḏ=ām la=haššib=ō*
 against=him **in_order_to** rescue\INF OBJ=him from=hand=theirs to=return\CAUS.INF=him
 'el 'ābī=w
 to father=his
 'But Reuben said to them, "Don't shed blood; throw him into this pit in the desert but do not stretch out your hand against them," *in order to* rescue him out of their hand to return him to his father.'

In (46), the fact that Reuben tries to save Joseph is not yet known to the Addressee (the reader). It can be accommodated based on the contents of the direct speech report, but even this is not always the case. For instance, in (47) with the purposive construction לְ *la* 'to' + infinitive, there is no reason in particular to think that Laban should go shear his sheep at this moment:

- (47) Gen. 31:19: וְלָבָן הָלַךְ לְגִזּוֹ אֶת־צֹאֲנוֹ: *wə-lābān hālak li=gzōz 'et šō'n=ō*
 and=Laban go\PFV[3M.SG] to=shear\INF OBJ flock=his
 'And Laban had gone *in order to* shear his sheep.'

Nevertheless, we do not find such cases with resultative *kī*. Even in cases with future reference time, the resultative clause refers to the Common Ground because the prospected result has already been discussed. For instance, in (48), though the resultative is an irrealis with future time reference, it refers directly back to Saul's proposal in the previous verse.

- (48) 1 Sam. 18:18: מִי אֶנֶכִּי ... כִּי־אֶהְיֶה חַתָּן לְמֶלֶךְ: *mī 'ānōkī ... kī 'ehye ḥātān l=am=melek*
 who I ... COMP 1SG-be\IPFV son_in_law to=the=king
 '(Saul said to David: "Here is my oldest daughter Merab; I want to give her to you in marriage ..."
 But David said to Saul:) "Who am I ... *that* [you say that] I should be the king's son-in-law?"'

This supports the hypothesis that *kī* is marked for reference to the Common Ground.

6.3 Concessive clauses

With a concessive clause (English *though*) the Speaker concedes some information to the Addressee, but at the same time denies that this information is incompatible with the assertion made in the matrix clause:

- (49) 2 Sam. 12:12: כִּי אַתָּה עָשִׂיתָ בְּסֵתֶר וְאֲנִי אֶעֱשֶׂה אֶת־הַדָּבָר הַזֶּה נֶגֶד כָּל־יִשְׂרָאֵל
kī attā āsī-tā b=as=sāter wa=’ānī ’e’ēše ’et had=dābār haz=ze
 COMP you do\PFV-2M.SG in=the=secret and=I 1SG-do\IPFV OBJ the=thing the=this
neḡed kāl yisrā’el
 before all.of Israel
 ‘*Though* you have acted in secret, I will do this before all of Israel.’

A concessive usually presupposes that the Addressee knows or can easily accommodate the conceded information. For instance, in English I can utter (50) only to someone of whom I know that they share my belief about France’s likelihood to win; I have to assume that *France won’t win this World Championship* is in the Common Ground or easily accommodated.

- (50) *Though France won’t win this World Championship, they are a treat to watch.*

The fact that concessive clauses always refer to Common Ground makes it pointless to compare *kī* with other markers of concessive clauses, such as ׀ *’im* (Job 9:15; Jer. 15:1) or ׀ *wə* (e.g. Jdg. 16:15). However, the fact that the cases with *kī* all refer to information in the Common Ground or easily accommodated is of course in line with my proposal.

6.4 Low-frequency circumstantial clauses: summary

This section has reviewed four types of less frequent circumstantial *kī*-clauses: temporal, conditional, resultative, and concessive clauses. It is particularly important that these lower frequency uses of *kī* adhere to the predicted patterns, since they are a priori less likely to have bleached and lost the [+distal] feature. The data reveal that in these *kī*-clauses the information provided in the clause is indeed always in the Common Ground, easily accommodated, or (rarely) imposed on the Common Ground for a discursive effect. This confirms the hypothesis that *kī* still has a [+distal] feature, which is interpreted as referring to the Addressee, and thus to the Common Ground.

7 Standalone *kī*-clauses

As is well-known and seen in the previous sections, *kī* usually connects two clauses. After classifying all instances of *kī* for the relation it establishes between the two clauses, some instances remained for which it is not clear that *kī* really connects two clauses. Though these cases have often been seen as deviant in the literature on Biblical Hebrew (for instance, they prompt Park 2016 to propose that *kī* is a “nominalizer”), they are actually to be expected when we look at similar clausal connectives in other languages. For instance, English *that* can be used in matrix clauses (see (5) above), as can Romance complementizers derived from Latin *quod* (Cruschina & Remberger 2017; Kocher 2022); for more discussion, see Mithun (2016). Scholars of Biblical Hebrew have described similar instances with *kī* as “emphatic” or “asseverative” (e.g. Joüon & Muraoka 2006: §164; Miller 2003: 103–116; Holmstedt 2010: 76, 85, 92). Because these terms are met with criticism for being vague (e.g. Bandstra 1982; Aejmelaeus 1986; Locatell 2017), I have classified these instances as “standalone” to avoid committing to any analysis upfront. A closer look reveals that there are three ways in which standalone *kī* can be used: to introduce oaths (section 7.1), conducive and rhetorical polar questions (section 7.2), or exclamatives (section 7.3). Each of these functions can reasonably be called “emphatic”, but it is valuable to be precise what kinds of emphasis can be provided by *kī*, exactly, to prevent this category from becoming a universal catch-all.

7.1 Oaths

Oaths can be described as sincere and earnest speech acts meant to assure the Addressee of a certain assertion or promise (Conklin 2011: 2). They are typically accompanied by what Conklin (2011: 13–30)

calls an “authenticating element” that is meant to assure the Addressee of the Speaker’s sincerity, such as ‘life of Yahweh’ in (51):⁴³

- (51) 2 Sam. 12:5: חַי־יְהוָה כִּי בָרַחַת הָאִישׁ הָעֹשֶׂה זֹאת: *hay yhw h kī ben māwet hā=’iš hā=’ōsé zō’t*
 life.of Yahweh COMP son.of death the=man the=do\PTCP[M.SG] this
 ‘By the life of Yahweh, *that* the man who does this is a dead man!’

There are 17 cases of standalone *kī* introducing an oath in my corpus, of which only six refer to discourse-old information content.⁴⁴ For example, in (52), the previous verse has already made the question of when the people will stop pursuing their brothers a topic of discussion, and therefore tracked in the Common Ground:

- (52) 2 Sam. 2:27ab: וַיֹּאמֶר יוֹאָב חַי הַאֱלֹהִים כִּי לֹא דִבַּרְתָּ כִּי אֲזַמְחֶקֶר נַעֲלָה הָעָם אִישׁ מֵאַחֲרֵי אָחִיו: *way-y-ō’mer yō’āb hay hā=’ēlōhīm kī lūlē’ dibbar-tā kī āz*
 CONJ-3M-say\PRET[SG] Joab life.of the=god COMP had_not speak\PFV-2M.SG COMP then
mē=hab=bōqer na’ālā hā=’ām ’iš mē=ahārē āhī=w
 from=the=morning go_up\MID.PFV[3M.SG] the=people(M) one from=behind brother=his
 ‘(Abner called out to Joab: “... How long won’t you tell the people to return from after their brothers?”) And Joab said: “By the life of the deity, ([I swear] *that*) had you not spoken, (*that*) then [only] from the morning onwards would the people have ceased [pursuing], each from behind his brother.”

Usually, however, the content of the oath is not discourse-old, and cannot be accommodated either. Instead, it is imposed on the Common Ground.⁴⁵ This is also how I analyze (51) above. It is precisely the imposition that triggers the interpretation as an oath. Forcing the Addressee to accept an assertion in the Common Ground, the Speaker effectively assures the Addressee of their own sincerity and commitment to this assertion, which is precisely what an oath does (Conklin 2011: 2).

Conklin’s explanation for the use of *kī* to mark oaths is reminiscent of Ross’s (1970) performative hypothesis: *kī* would be a remnant of an originally longer formula (*I swear that ...*) after elision of the predicate (Conklin 2011: 59). There are well-known problems with this approach in its most basic form (see Speas & Tenny 2003: 338 for discussion), but even if we were to accept it, some questions remain. For example, it is unclear why the complementizer would not have been elided together with the predicate in oath formulas, with only intonation serving to distinguish the exclamative from a declarative (as in some rhetorical questions, like *I said something funny?*, and interrogatives more generally in languages like Italian). The analysis proposed in the present article provides an explanation why the complementizer was retained: it is crucial to oaths that they impose information on the Common Ground, and this aspect is marked by the [+distal] complementizer.

7.2 Conducive and rhetorical questions

There are five instances in my corpus of conducive and rhetorical questions using the polar interrogative marker *hā* followed by *kī*, two of which are negated (כִּי לֹא *hā-lō’ kī*).⁴⁶ In one instance (2 Sam. 9:1), *hā-kī* introduces a regular question which happens to nominalize a clause of which the content is under discussion in the Common Ground;⁴⁷ this instance is excluded here and classified as a subject clause. I will rely on Moshavi (2009) for my analysis of the five instances under discussion here; see there for more background and references on these types of questions.

⁴³Besides *kī*, a number of other particles can be used to introduce oaths (Conklin 2011: 60–65), but they do not appear often enough to allow for a comparison with *kī*. For this reason I will only discuss oaths with *kī* in this subsection.

⁴⁴1 Sam. 20:13; 25:34ab; 29:6a; 2 Sam. 2:27a; Ruth 1:17.

⁴⁵1 Sam. 14:39b; 20:3b; 20:12; 26:10, 16; 2 Sam. 3:9ab, 35; 12:5; 15:21ab.

⁴⁶Without negation: Gen. 27:36; 29:15; 2 Sam. 23:19. With negation: 1 Sam. 10:1; 2 Sam. 13:28.

⁴⁷Similar to one more example outside my corpus, Job 6:22.

A rhetorical question has the form of an interrogative but is, at the discursive level, an implicit assertion rather than a request for information (Moshavi 2009: 32). The implicit assertion contributed by a rhetorical polar question is the negation of its propositional content: *Are you the president?* implies that you are not the president (Moshavi 2009: 33). A conducive question is similar to a rhetorical question in that the Speaker has a certain prior belief regarding the correct answer, and may not expect an answer. However, unlike a rhetorical question it does not function as an implicit assertion. For example, *Is that you, Henry?* does not imply that you are Henry but merely conveys an expectation (Moshavi 2009: 38). Moshavi describes the discursive functions of conducive questions in Biblical Hebrew as (a) confirming a belief of the Speaker, (b) expressing surprise, (c) showing the Addressee that the Speaker knows something to be true, and (d) drawing attention to a fact (2009: 38 n. 38).

The questions with *hā-kī* ‘is [it] that’ are conducive, implying that the information content of the *kī*-clause is true:

- (53) Gen. 27:36: הֲכִי קִיָּא שְׁמוֹ יַעֲקֹב וַיַּעֲקֹבֵנִי זֶה פַּעַמַּיִם
hā=kī qārā’ šəm=ō ya’āqōb way-y-a’qəb=ēnī zε
 Q=COMP call\PFV[3M.SG] name(M)=his Jacob CONJ-3M-deceive\PRET[SG]=me this
pā’ām-ayim
 time-DU
 ‘Isn’t his name Jacob?⁴⁸ He has deceived me these two times!’

In the case of conducive questions with *kī*, the information content is not only implied but also well-known to be true, and thus in the Common Ground. Compared to conducive questions without *kī*, the questions with *kī* convey a much stronger belief with respect to the expected answer. In (54) without *kī* the Speaker is much less certain that Saul should now be considered a prophet than that the Speaker in (53) is certain about Jacob’s name. This explains why *kī* can be used in (53) but not (54): only in (53) can the propositional content be assumed to be in the Common Ground. In (54), the Speaker does not even want to impose it on the Common Ground.

- (54) 1 Sam. 10:11: וַיְהִי כָּל־יְיָדְעוֹ מֵאֵתְמוֹל שְׁלֹשׁ וַיֵּרְאוּ וְהִנֵּה עִם־נָבִיאִים נִבָּא וַיֹּאמְרוּ הֲעַם אִישׁ אֶל־רֵעֵהוּ מִה־זֶּה הִיא לְבִן־קִישׁ הֲגַם שְׂאוֹל בְּנִי־אִיִּם
wa-y-ahī kāl yōdā’=ō mē=’ittāmōl šilšōm way-y-ir’-ū
 CONJ-3M-be\PRET[SG] all.of know\PTCP[M.SG]=him from=before CONJ-3M-see\PRET-PL
wə=hinnē ‘im nabi’-īm nibbā’ way-y-ō’mēr hā=’ām
 and=behold with prophet-PL prophesy\PTCP[M.SG] CONJ-3M-say\PRET[SG] the=people(M)
’iš ‘el rē’=ēhū mah zε hāyā lə=ben qūš hā=gam šā’ul
 one to companion=his what this be\PFV[3M.SG] to=son.of Kish Q=also Saul
b=an=nabi’-īm
 in=the=prophet-PL
 ‘And when all who knew [Saul] from before saw how he prophesied with prophets, the people said to each other: “What happened to the son of Kish? Is Saul also among the prophets?”’

The questions with *hā-lō’ kī* ‘isn’t [it] that’ are rhetorical. Due to double negation (once for *lō’* ‘not’ and once for the rhetorical question), these questions also imply that the information content of the *kī*-clause is true:

⁴⁸The name Jacob translates as ‘he-will-deceive’. Note that my translation uses a rhetorical question, and thus adds negation. Another option is “No wonder his name is Jacob” (NLT; cf. also NET). One can also take this *kī* as causal (‘Is it because his name is Jacob that ...’), which is also possible in Gen. 29:15 but not in 2 Sam. 23:19.

- (55) 1 Sam. 10:1: וַיִּקַּח שְׁמוּאֵל אֶת־פֶּדֶךְ הַשֶּׁמֶן וַיִּצֹק עַל־רֹאשׁוֹ וַיִּשְׁקָהוּ וַיֹּאמֶר הֲלוֹא כִּי־מִשְׁחָךְ יְהוָה עַל־נַחֲלָתוֹ לְנִגִּיד׃
way-y-iqqah šəmū’el ’et pak haš=šemen way-y-išōq
CONJ-3M-take\PRET[SG] Samuel OBJ flask.of the=oil CONJ-3M-pour\PRET[SG]
‘al rōš=ō way-y-iššāq=ēhū way-y-ō’mēr hā=lo’ kī
on head=his CONJ-3M-kiss\PRET[SG]=him CONJ-3M-say\PRET[SG] Q=not COMP
mašāḥ=ākā yhwh ‘al naḥălāt=ō lə=nāgīd
anoint\PFV[3M.SG]=you.OBJ Yahweh over inheritance=his for=leader
‘Then Samuel took a flask of oil and poured it on [Saul]’s head, and he kissed him and said: “Has Yahweh *not* anointed you as leader over his inheritance?”’

In the other rhetorical question, Common Ground is imposed by making an implicit assertion (2 Sam. 13:28). A rhetorical question does not leave room for the Addressee to reject the implied assertion, and thus has the effect of imposing it on the Common Ground. Though the use of *kī* is not necessary to form these types of questions (see Moshavi 2009 for many examples without *kī*), it is still well-suited because of this interaction with the Common Ground.

7.3 Exclamatives

The third way in which standalone *kī* is used is to form exclamatives. Exclamatives are sentences that “express the speaker’s affective response to a situation” (Michaelis 2001: 1039). As with conducive and rhetorical questions, a proposition can be recovered from an exclamative: *What nice weather it is!* implies that it is nice weather. Crucially, the Speaker of an exclamative assumes this propositional content to be in the Common Ground (Zanuttini & Portner 2003): *What nice weather it is!* cannot be used to convince the Addressee that it is nice weather. This distinguishes exclamatives from both declarative sentences, which make no such assumption, and rhetorical questions, which impose information on the Common Ground rather than assuming it is already shared with the Addressee. Nevertheless, this reference to Common Ground makes *kī* a natural element to mark exclamatives (cf. Mithun 2016 and Staps & Rooryck 2023: 10–12 for comparative parallels).

In the examples found in the Hebrew Bible, exclamatives with *kī* express shock/outrage (56)⁴⁹ or commitment (57) with respect to the recoverable proposition, though there is no reason to think other emotions could not be expressed this way as well.

- (56) Gen. 18:20ab: וַעֲקַת סְדֹם וְעִמּוֹרָה כִּי־רָבָה וְחַטָּאתָם כִּי כְבֵדָה מְאֹד׃
za’āqa-t sədōm wa=’āmōrā kī rābb-ā wə=ḥattā’t=ām kī
outcry(F)-of Sodom and=Gomorrah COMP be_great\PFV-3F.SG and=sin(F)=theirs COMP
kāḇad-ā mə’ōd
be_heavy\PFV-3F.SG very
‘That the outcry of/concerning Sodom and Gomorrah is so great! And *that* their sin is so heavy!’
- (57) 1 Sam. 10:24: הֲרֵאיתֶם אֲשֶׁר בָּחַרְבּוֹ יְהוָה כִּי אֵין כָּמֹהוּ בְּכָל־הָעָם׃
har=rā’ī-tēm āšer bāḥar b=ō yhwh kī ’en kāmō=hū
Q=see\PFV-2M.PL REL choose\PFV[3M.SG] on=him Yahweh COMP not_exists like=him
bə=kāl hā=ām
in=all.of the=people
‘Do you see whom Yahweh has chosen? *That* no one like him (=Saul) exists among all the people!’

⁴⁹Some translations take these instances of *kī* as causal, providing a reason for the following clause (‘I will go down ...’: KJV; ESV), but modern versions provide support for an exclamative reading (NASB/AMP: “the outcry ... is *indeed* great, and their sin is *exceedingly* grave”). For other examples, see 1 Sam. 17:28 and perhaps Gen. 45:26a, if we assume that the brothers are in part speaking to each other (this explanation is not ideal, but I have no better alternative at this point).

These examples refer to Common Ground in the following way. In (56), God speaks to Abraham. Abraham has already had previous contact with Sodom in Genesis 13–14, where he has been able to see that the Sodomites are *rā'im wə-ḥattā'im* ‘wicked and sinners’ (Gen. 13:13). This allows the Speaker to presuppose this information, and thus permits the interpretation as an exclamation. Example (57) is spoken by Samuel after he has proclaimed Saul king. Similar to (56), the claim that there is no one like Saul among the people can be accommodated by the Addressee (the people) from the fact that Saul has just been made king.

It is also possible to express commitment towards a wish, which has the effect of strengthening a wish (58).⁵⁰ It should be noted that in these cases the fact that the Speaker has a certain desire is discourse-old: in (58), it is already clear to the Addressee that the Speaker wants the spoil to be divided equally. It thus does not appear to be possible to strengthen just any wish with *kī*.

- (58) 1 Sam. 30:24: כִּי כְחֶלֶק הַיָּרֵד בְּמִלְחָמָה וְכְחֶלֶק הַיֹּשֵׁב עַל-הַכּוֹלִים יִחָדּוּ יְחֻלְקוּ׃
kī *kə=ḥēleq* *hay=yōrēd* *b=am=milḥāmā* *ū=kə=ḥēleq*
 COMP like=part.of the=go_down\PTCP[M.SG] in=the=battle and=like=part.of
hay=yōšēb *‘al hak=kēl-īm yaḥdāw* *y-aḥālōq-ū*
 the=sit\PTCP[M.SG] on the=item-PL together 3M-divide\IPFV-PL
 (“Since they didn’t go with me, we will not give them from the spoil. ...” But David said: “No! ...”) *That* as the part of he who goes down in battle, so be the part of he who remains with the equipment! Together they shall divide it.”

Exclamatives are clearly emphatic, but it is a much narrower category than “emphatic” or “asseverative” *kī*. Before classifying an instance of *kī* as an exclamation it must be shown that the propositional content is in the Common Ground or easily accommodated by the Addressee. This more precise description of the function of *kī* can thus help prevent overly liberal use of the notion of “emphatic” *kī*.

8 Conclusion

The primary function of Biblical Hebrew *kī* is to mark reference to Common Ground, which includes reference to easily accommodated and imposed information content. Deviations from this general pattern mostly occur in the most common function, causal *kī* (section 4). I therefore conclude that some semantic bleaching must have occurred here (section 4.2), which subsequently transferred to the semantically closely related categories of causal-adversative and adversative *kī* (section 5). In all other functions, the vast majority of instances refer to the Common Ground. Though grammaticalization is required to account for the use of *kī* to introduce subject and object clauses (section 3), we do not need to assume intricate grammaticalization paths to account for the various circumstantial uses of *kī* (section 6; contra e.g. Locatelli 2017, 2020). These are more economically described as pragmatically inferred uses based on the general function of marking Common Ground; since some of these functions are very infrequent, assuming semantic shifts for which we do not have evidence is problematic. Taking all of this into account, I propose a description of *kī* with only three distinct functions:

1. Referring to Common Ground (including easily accommodated and imposed information content)
 - (a) As a complementizer introducing subject and object clauses
 - (b) When connecting two clauses: introducing circumstantial clauses (adversative, causal, causal-adversative, concessive, conditional, resultative, temporal)⁵¹

⁵⁰ Also 1 Sam. 8:9; 14:44 (if not an oath); 25:28a.

⁵¹ Given that some of these types are very infrequent, it is conceivable that there are still other types of circumstantial clauses that could be marked by *kī*, which have not made their way into the corpus. This is fine, as long as the information content is in the Common Ground and the discursive function can be inferred from context.

- (c) When standalone: introducing oaths, conducive and rhetorical questions (with הָ *hā*), and exclamatives
- 2. Bleached causal meaning ('because', 'for', etc.)
- 3. Bleached adversative meaning ('but'), developed from causal via causal-adversative ('not X, *but/because* Y')

Some authors, Aejmelaeus (1986: 193–194) most verbosely, have wondered how native speakers could have distinguished the many uses of *kī*. Though this study is based on texts and not native speaker judgments, the three functions above suggest a straightforward answer. The most common and default function of *kī* is to mark Common Ground. When the Addressee cannot accommodate the information content of a *kī*-clause, this triggers them to use one of the bleached meanings instead, choosing between causal and adversative based on context. In its default function of marking Common Ground, one of the three subfunctions can be selected based on simple cues: the existence of a matrix predicate or the place of the *kī*-clause in subject position for complementizer *kī*, authenticating elements for oaths, the interrogative particle for questions, and intonation for exclamatives; anything else is circumstantial. The appropriate kind of circumstantial meaning can be selected based on context.

The function of marking Common Ground can be explained in the framework of Staps & Rooryck (2023). In their model, information content is conceptualized as located in an abstract space, in which it can be “near” or “far from” Speaker and Addressee. I have argued that the Biblical Hebrew particle *kī* has inherited a [+distal] feature, which on the discourse level positions information content “far” from the Speaker, and therefore “near” the Addressee. The effect is that it marks Common Ground, which consists of information content known to the Addressee. The analysis presented here thus lends further support to the idea that information content is conceptualized as positioned in an abstract space (Staps & Rooryck 2023), and that highly grammaticalized function words like clausal connectives can retain features like [+distal] that receive a new interpretation in this abstract context.

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Appendix: Biblical Hebrew

Biblical Hebrew is a Northwest Semitic language spoken during the whole first millennium before the common era and into the first centuries of the common era. It is preserved primarily in the Hebrew Bible (which formed the basis for the Christian Old Testament), which is compiled from sources of diverse origins in terms of both space and time. Though working with an ancient language has the

obvious drawback that no constructed examples can be tested with native speakers, this is mitigated by the availability of a long history of translation and interpretation. Thus, although the translations provided are my own, the underlying interpretations are corroborated by standard translations.

Like that of other Semitic languages, the Biblical Hebrew verbal system is based on triconsonantal roots, with templates consisting of affixes and vowel patterns to express Aktionsart (simple, pluractional, and causative) and Voice (active, passive, reflexive, and middle). When the meaning of a stem in a certain template is lexicalized I will simply give an appropriate English translation without glossing the template. There are two main finite conjugations: a suffix conjugation used in perfective/gnomic aspect and/or past tense contexts, and a prefix conjugation used in imperfective aspect, non-past tense, and various modal contexts. In keeping with traditional terminology I will gloss these forms PFV and IPFV, respectively, keeping in mind that their semantics is broader than this. In addition to these two conjugations there is a sequential preterite form used in narratives (traditionally called *wayyiqtol*, glossed here as CONJ-...-stem\PRET), and a sequential modal form (traditionally called *waqāṭaltī*, glossed here as CONJ-stem\MOD). Besides the imperative (IMP) of the second person, Biblical Hebrew has a jussive (JUSS) of the second and third person. Biblical Hebrew morphologically distinguishes two types of infinitives: the “infinitive construct” (INF), which is most like infinitives and gerunds in Indo-European; and an “infinitive absolute” (INFABS), the use of which is more complicated, but in the examples in this article is limited to strengthening an immediately following finite form of the same verb.

Nominals inflect for gender (masculine or feminine) and number (singular, plural, or dual; the latter of limited productivity). Verbs agree with their subject in person, gender, and number (but plural forms are used for dual subjects, and the first person has common gender). I only indicate gender on nouns where needed to clarify agreement. In possessive constructions, the possessed noun is in the “construct state”, which is morphologically distinguished from the default “absolute state” for certain combinations of gender and number; I gloss nouns in the construct state with “-of” (when morphologically marked) or “.of” (when syncretic with the absolute state).

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